Large Language Models as Nonlinear Dynamical Systems: The Three Clocks of Depth, Training, and Generation

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Abstract

A transformer language model is iterated in three ways: over layers, where the residual stream of each token is updated step by step; over optimizer steps, where the weights evolve under gradient descent; and over generated tokens, where the model feeds its own samples back as input. We call these the three clocks of a language model. Each clock has its own literature on clustering, edge of stability, loss spikes, grokking, repetition loops and temperature transitions, and these literatures rarely cite each other or the nonlinear dynamics they draw on. We place the three clocks in one framework of coupled maps, review about 200 papers, and condense the results into the Three-Clock Dictionary, which maps fifteen concepts from nonlinear dynamics onto each clock and marks every correspondence as proved, measured or conjectured. Paired figures put a textbook mechanical system and a language model in the same representation, and reduced-order models explain why they match: the softmax is a Boltzmann distribution, gradient descent is an Euler step on a nonlinear spring, attention on the circle is a Kuramoto model, and a repetition loop is a well that deepens while it is occupied. All experiments on open models run on a laptop CPU. Training makes each layer of a Pythia model stretch perturbations more strongly, while the forward pass as a whole changes little. At the edge of stability of a small transformer, two to six Hessian eigenvalues exceed $2/\eta$ while the curvature along the step stays at $2/\eta$. Escape from repetition loops in GPT-2 and Pythia follows the Arrhenius law of Kramers' escape problem, with the logit gap as the barrier, and the barrier deepens while the model repeats itself and then saturates. A loop therefore never locks for good, but the temperature needed to leave it within a budget of N cycles falls like $1/\ln N$, and it rises with model size, by about half from 70M to 1B parameters. Coherent text occupies a narrow window of temperatures between repetition and incoherence. A small reasoning model shows the same window, with its best accuracy at the recommended temperature, but below it the model rethinks the same step instead of looping. We close with twelve open problems and release code, data and a maintained reading list.

1 Introduction

A transformer language model is a nonlinear map. It takes a context, a sequence of tokens, and returns a probability distribution over the next token, much as a forced pendulum maps an initial condition and an excitation to a history of displacements.[1] The analogy has one important limit. In a mechanical model the parameters, such as the length of a pendulum or the stiffness of a frame under earthquake loading, are fixed or prescribed from outside, whereas a learning model changes its own parameters, and it does so through a second dynamical system, the training algorithm. A language model is therefore used as an iterated map in at least three different ways, and each of these iterations has its own literature, its own vocabulary and its own catalogue of strange behavior.

[1] Use of AI tools: an AI assistant (Claude, Anthropic) helped search and verify the literature, draft and edit text, and write and run the experiment code, under the author's direction. All references were checked against arXiv or Crossref records and all reported numbers come from the released code. The author takes full responsibility for the content.

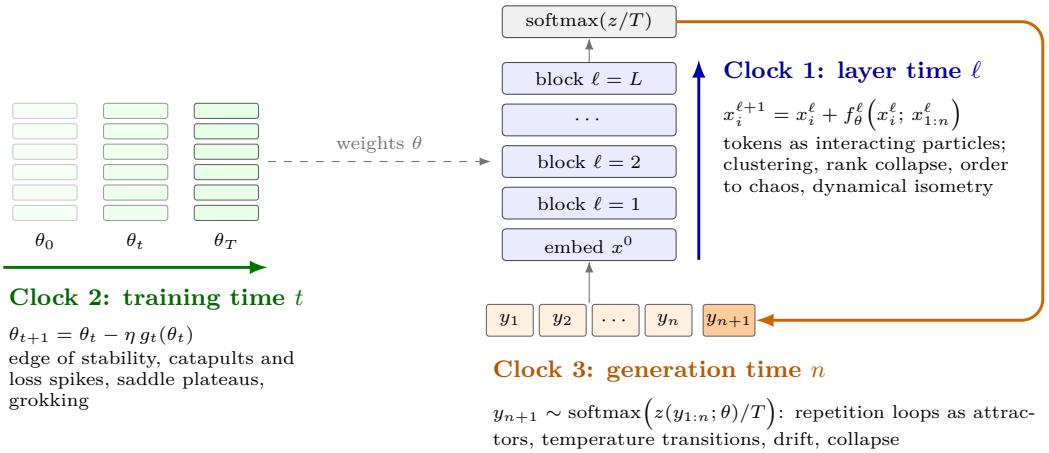


Figure 1: The three clocks of a transformer language model. **Clock 1** (blue) iterates the residual update over layers for a fixed input and fixed weights. **Clock 2** (green) iterates the optimizer over the weights; it hands its current weights to the model. **Clock 3** (orange) iterates sampling: each new token is appended to the context and the whole stack runs again. One tick of clock 3 contains a full run of clock 1, and clock 2 changes the map that both of them iterate. Typical behavior studied on each clock is listed next to it; Table 2 maps it onto dynamical-systems concepts.

The first iteration runs over depth. Each residual block adds an update to the hidden state of every token, so a stack of L blocks is a discrete-time dynamical system with the layer index as time (E, 2017; Haber & Ruthotto, 2017; Lu et al., 2017; Chen et al., 2018), and attention couples the tokens into a system of interacting particles (Lu et al., 2019; Sander et al., 2021b; Geshkovski et al., 2023b). The second iteration runs over optimization steps. Gradient descent is a map on parameter space, and at the step sizes used in practice it sits at the boundary of linear stability (Cohen et al., 2021), produces loss spikes (Chowdhery et al., 2022; Wortsman et al., 2023) and goes through abrupt transitions such as grokking (Power et al., 2022) and the formation of induction heads (Olsson et al., 2022). The third iteration runs over generated tokens. An autoregressive model feeds its own samples back as input, so decoding is a stochastic dynamical system on the space of contexts, and its best known pathology, the repetition loop (Holtzman et al., 2019; Xu et al., 2022), has recently been analyzed as an attractor (Wang et al., 2025; Jones, 2026).

We call these three iterations the *three clocks* of a language model, with layer time ℓ, training time t and generation time n (Figure 1). The clocks are coupled, since the parameters produced by clock 2 define the map iterated by clock 1, and every tick of clock 3 calls a full run of clock 1. They also run at very different rates, since the weights do not move during generation and each weight update in training averages over many forward passes. Separated time scales of this kind are the standard setting of slow-fast dynamical systems (Strogatz, 2018), and they explain why three literatures could grow up around one object with few citations between them.

The cost of this separation is that well-understood dynamics is rediscovered under new names. Nonlinear dynamics has a mature theory for the behaviors that appear on the three clocks, built over more than a century on pendulums, rotating machinery, ships, lasers and networks of coupled oscillators: stability and bifurcations, synchronization, chaos and Lyapunov exponents, and noise-driven escape from potential wells (Strogatz, 2018; Kramers, 1940; Hänggi et al., 1990; Acebrón et al., 2005). These tools transfer directly. Escape from a repetition loop at sampling temperature T is the escape of a particle from a potential well under noise of intensity T, with the gap between the logits of the repeated token and its best competitor in the role of the barrier. The Arrhenius form of the Kramers rate then predicts how the escape probability depends on temperature, and the measured growth of the barrier predicts how long a loop survives (Section 5.2 and Experiment 3). The exchange also runs the other way. Neural networks already forecast spatiotemporally chaotic systems from data (Pathak et al., 2018) and learn coordinates in which nonlinear dynamics becomes

linear (Lusch et al., 2017), and a trained transformer is itself a high-dimensional, nonautonomous system that can be run millions of times, observed completely and differentiated exactly.

A bridge between two fields can carry three kinds of traffic. The first is description, in which a behavior seen in one field receives a model, a name and a set of measurable quantities from the other, so that a repetition loop becomes a periodic orbit and a step-to-step oscillation of the loss becomes a period-2 orbit of a map. The second is explanation, in which the tools of the older field account for why the behavior occurs and predict how it changes with a parameter, as Kramers' theory predicts how the rate of escape from a well changes with the noise. The third is solution, in which the explanation points to an intervention that fixes a problem the newer field had not solved. Most of this paper works at the first two levels. Figures 2 to 5 show the description directly, with a mechanical system and a language model drawn in the same representation, and Section 2.3 explains each correspondence with a reduced-order model, in the way an engineer replaces a sloshing tank or a rolling ship by an equivalent oscillator. The softmax turns out to be a Boltzmann distribution, gradient descent an Euler step on a nonlinear spring, attention on the circle a Kuramoto model, and a repetition loop a well that deepens while it is occupied. At the third level we tested three controllers derived from the escape analysis on GPT-2. They remove exact loops and find the temperature window without a sweep, but none produces more coherent text than the best fixed temperature, because the trap is stored in the context while the controllers act on the noise (**OP 12**). Solutions at this level remain the main open task, and the open problems of Section 8 list the places where we expect them.

In the current work we build this bridge in both directions. We write the three clocks in the language of nonlinear dynamics, record which correspondences are proved, measured or only conjectured, and use the tools of the field to explain behavior that the machine learning literature documents but does not yet explain. Our contributions are the following.

1. **A unified framework.** We formalize the three clocks as coupled maps, show textbook physical systems and language models side by side, and derive the reduced-order models behind each correspondence (Section 2) and review the dynamical-systems results for each clock (Sections 3, 4 and 5), drawing on about 200 papers from machine learning theory, interpretability, optimization, statistical physics and applied mathematics.
2. **The Three-Clock Dictionary.** Table 2 maps fifteen concepts from nonlinear dynamics (fixed points, limit cycles, period doubling, Lyapunov exponents, basins, metastability, noise-driven escape, synchronization, Koopman linearization and others) onto observed behavior on each clock, with the evidence level of every entry. An empty cell marks a concept that no study we found has tested on that clock, and each such cell defines a research question.
3. **Experiments** on open models that run on a laptop CPU (Section 7). We measure how the per-layer Lyapunov profile of the residual stream changes over training in the public Pythia checkpoints (Biderman et al., 2023), we compute a learning-rate bifurcation diagram of a small transformer trained by full-batch gradient descent and show that at the edge of stability several Hessian eigenvalues exceed $2/\eta$ while the curvature along the step stays at $2/\eta$, and we show that escape from repetition loops in GPT-2 and Pythia follows an Arrhenius law with the logit gap as the Kramers barrier (Kramers, 1940), a barrier that grows while the model stays in the loop and then saturates. We prove that logarithmic growth would give a sharp locking temperature, show that the measured growth saturates instead, so that the locking temperature falls with the length of the generation and rises with model size from 70M to 1B parameters, and map the narrow window of temperatures between repetitive and incoherent text. In a small reasoning model the same window appears, centered on the temperature its developers recommend, but its lower edge is set by recurrent rethinking, and no exact loop forms.
4. **Twelve open problems** (Section 8), each stated with a first test.

Several papers develop one of these views in depth, and we rely on them throughout. Geshkovski et al. (2023b) and Castin et al. (2025) develop the mathematics of attention as an interacting particle system over depth. Cohen et al. (2021) and the work that followed analyze gradient descent at the edge of stability. Krishnamurthy et al. (2026) give a stochastic dynamical-systems account of autoregressive generation and of networks of interacting language models, and Jones (2026) studies chaos and bifurcations in a deterministic

feedback version of generation. To our knowledge, no earlier work treats the three clocks side by side in one vocabulary, with an explicit record of which correspondences are proved, which are measured and which are conjectures.

We use the language of dynamical systems in its technical sense wherever a result supports it, and we flag analogies as analogies. For example, we call a loss spike a bifurcation only when a parameter can be shown to cross a stability threshold. The paper is written for machine learning researchers who want a compact entry into dynamical-systems tools, and for dynamicists who want to know which of their tools are already in use on language models. Section 2 is a primer for the first group, and the dictionary in Section 6 is intended for both.

Practical takeaways.

- *Generation.* In GPT-2 and Pythia, coherent text appears only in a narrow band of temperatures between repetition and incoherence, and for some prompts in none. A loop is not locked by a fixed temperature: the temperature needed to leave it within a given budget falls like $1/\ln N$ with the length N of the generation, and larger models need a higher temperature to leave the same kind of loop (Section 7.3). In Qwen3-0.6B on GSM8K, accuracy within a fixed budget peaks at the vendor's $T = 0.6$, and below it the model rethinks the same step until the budget runs out.
- *Anti-repetition.* Raising the temperature when a loop starts, rolling the text back to the start of the loop, or steering the temperature by feedback all remove exact loops, but none beats the best fixed temperature on coherent text, because the attractor is stored in the context, not in the sampler (**OP 12**).
- *Training.* At the edge of stability several Hessian eigenvalues sit 5% to 14% above $2/\eta$ while the curvature along the actual step equals $2/\eta$, so $\eta\lambda_{\max} > 2$ alone does not signal divergence. A power iteration can underestimate $\lambda_{\max}$ there, because the top eigenvalues form a cluster that reorders at every step (Section 7.2).
- *Depth.* Training makes each layer stretch perturbations more, while the stretched directions of consecutive layers become less aligned (Section 7.1).
- *Tools.* Per-layer Lyapunov exponents, learning-rate bifurcation diagrams and exact loop-escape probabilities from a single greedy pass all run on a laptop CPU, and the code is released.

2 The three clocks, and a primer on the tools

2.1 Three coupled maps

Fix a decoder-only transformer (Vaswani et al., 2017) with L residual blocks, model width d and vocabulary $\mathcal{V}$. For a context of n tokens, write $x^\ell = (x_1^\ell, \dots, x_n^\ell) \in \mathbb{R}^{n\times d}$ for the residual stream after block ℓ, and θ for all parameters. The model defines three maps.

Definition 1 (Clock 1: layer time)**.** For fixed θ and fixed input tokens,

$$x^{\ell+1} = x^\ell + f_\theta^\ell(x^\ell), \qquad \ell = 0, \dots, L-1, \tag{1}$$

where f_θ^ℓ contains attention, which couples token i to tokens $j \le i$, and a token-wise MLP. The logits are $z = W_U\,\mathrm{LN}(x_n^L)$.

Definition 2 (Clock 2: training time)**.** For a loss $\mathcal{L}$ and data stream ξ_t,

$$\theta_{t+1} = \theta_t - \eta_t\, P_t\, \nabla_\theta \ell(\theta_t; \xi_t), \qquad t = 0, 1, \dots \tag{2}$$

where P_t is a preconditioner (identity for gradient descent, a diagonal matrix built from gradient moments for Adam) and $\ell(\cdot; \xi_t)$ is the minibatch loss. With full batches the map is deterministic; with minibatches it is a random dynamical system.

Definition 3 (Clock 3: generation time)**.** For fixed θ, a sampling temperature $T > 0$ and a context $s_n = (y_1, \dots, y_n)$,

$$y_{n+1} \sim \pi_T(\cdot \mid s_n) = \mathrm{softmax}\big(z(s_n;\theta)/T\big), \qquad s_{n+1} = (s_n, y_{n+1}). \tag{3}$$

This is a Markov chain on the growing space of contexts. Truncation rules such as top-k or nucleus sampling change π_T but not the structure.

The three maps are nested. Evaluating $z(s_n;\theta)$ in equation 3 means running equation 1 to the end, and computing the gradient in equation 2 means running equation 1 on teacher-forced contexts. The weights produced by equation 2 define the maps in equation 1 and equation 3. In practice the clocks also run at very different speeds relative to each other: generation never changes θ, and a single training step changes the forward map only by $O(\eta)$. In the language of slow-fast systems, clock 2 is the slow variable and clocks 1 and 3 are fast dynamics evaluated at a frozen slow state (Strogatz, 2018). Two well-studied effects break this picture: in-context learning, where the fast clock 1 appears to run an optimizer of its own (von Oswald et al., 2022; Akyürek et al., 2022), and self-training on model outputs, where clock 3 feeds clock 2 (Shumailov et al., 2023; Bertrand et al., 2023). Both are discussed in Sections 3 and 5.

2.2 A short primer

This subsection collects the dynamical-systems vocabulary used later. Readers who know it can skip to Section 3; a longer treatment is in Strogatz (2018). For four of the tools we put a textbook system and a learning system side by side in the same representation (Figures 2 to 5), so that the correspondence can be seen before it is argued.

Maps, fixed points and stability. A discrete-time system is a map $u_{k+1} = F(u_k)$. A fixed point $u^* = F(u^*)$ is linearly stable if every eigenvalue of the Jacobian $DF(u^*)$ lies inside the unit circle. The textbook case is the explicit Euler scheme for a stiff ordinary differential equation: integrating $\dot{u} = -\lambda u$ with step h gives $u_{k+1} = (1 - h\lambda)u_k$, which converges only if $h\lambda < 2$ and otherwise oscillates with growing amplitude. Gradient descent with step size η on a quadratic with Hessian eigenvalue λ is the same map with $h = \eta$, and this one-line calculation is the origin of the threshold $2/\eta$ in the edge-of-stability literature (Section 4.1).

Periodic orbits and bifurcations. A period-k orbit is a fixed point of F^k, and under a change of parameter such orbits can appear, disappear or exchange stability. In a period-doubling bifurcation an eigenvalue crosses -1 and a period-2 orbit is born. The logistic map $u_{k+1} = ru_k(1 - u_k)$, introduced as a model of insect populations, passes through a cascade of such doublings to chaos as r grows (May, 1976), and the ratio of successive bifurcation intervals tends to a universal constant, $4.669\ldots$, for every smooth one-humped map (Feigenbaum, 1978). In a saddle-node bifurcation a pair of fixed points collides and disappears. Just past it the trajectory still slows down where the pair used to be (a "ghost"), which produces long plateaus followed by fast jumps (Strogatz, 2018; Dinc et al., 2025). Gradient descent on a double-well loss $L(u) = (u^2 - 1)^2/4$ already shows both behaviors as η grows. The minimum loses stability at $\eta = 1$, a doubling cascade follows, and near $\eta \approx 1.6$ the chaotic iterate hops between the two wells.

Lyapunov exponents. For a trajectory $u_0, u_1, \ldots$ the finite-time Lyapunov exponent over K steps is

$$\lambda_K(u_0) = \frac{1}{K} \log \sigma_{\max}\big(DF(u_{K-1}) \cdots DF(u_0)\big), \tag{4}$$

where $\sigma_{\max}$ is the largest singular value. Positive values mean that nearby trajectories separate exponentially, so that a perturbation of size δ reaches size one after about $\log(1/\delta)/\lambda$ steps. Lorenz (1963) found this sensitivity in a three-variable truncation of atmospheric convection, and it gives weather forecasts a finite horizon however accurate the initial data. The limit $K \to \infty$, when it exists, is the largest Lyapunov exponent. Deep networks have a fixed and small number of steps, so only finite-time exponents make sense for clock 1 (Storm et al., 2023).

Basins and metastability. The basin of attraction of an attractor is the set of initial conditions that reach it. Basin boundaries can be fractal (McDonald et al., 1985). In a periodically forced oscillator, such as a ship rolling in beam seas, the basin of safe motion around the upright state erodes into fractal fingers as the wave amplitude grows, so that capsizing becomes sensitive to the initial state well before the safe attractor

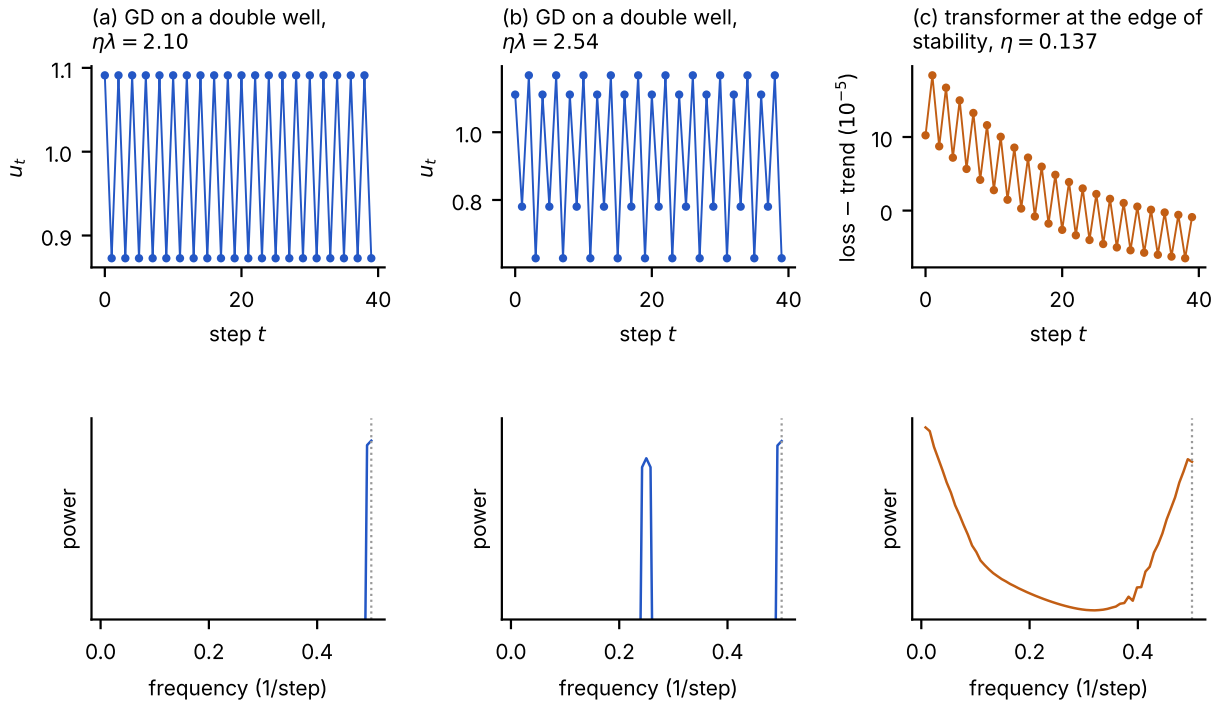


Figure 2: Training as a dynamical system: period two at the edge of stability. (a, b) Gradient descent on the double well $L(u) = (u^2 - 1)^2/4$, whose minimum has curvature $\lambda = 2$, with $\eta\lambda = 2.10$ and 2.54: the last 40 iterates lie on a period-2 and a period-4 orbit. (d, e) Their power spectra, with peaks at frequencies 1/2 and 1/4. (c) The one-block transformer of Experiment 2 trained by full-batch gradient descent at $\eta = 0.137$, at the edge of stability: training loss over the last 40 steps after removing a slow polynomial trend, in units of 10^{-5}. The loss alternates from step to step. (f) Spectrum of the detrended loss over the last 400 steps: the same peak at 1/2, on top of a low-frequency band from the slow modulation of the oscillation (Section 7.2).

itself disappears (Thompson & Soliman, 1990; Thompson, 1997). The set of trainable hyperparameters of a neural network has the same kind of boundary (Sohl-Dickstein, 2024). A metastable state is not an attractor but holds trajectories for a very long time, for example a cluster configuration of tokens that eventually merges (Geshkovski et al., 2024).

Telling regimes apart from data. An experimentalist who sees only a signal classifies the motion with four standard pictures. The time history shows the motion directly. In the power spectrum a periodic motion gives sharp peaks at its frequency and harmonics, and noise or chaos gives a broad band. In the phase portrait a periodic orbit is a closed curve and noise fills a region. The recurrence plot marks the pairs of times (i, j) at which the state returns close to itself, $R_{ij} = 1$ if $\|u_i - u_j\| < \varepsilon$, and a periodic orbit draws long lines parallel to the diagonal (Eckmann et al., 1987). Two numbers condense the last two pictures: the normalized entropy of the spectrum, H_s, from 0 for a single line to 1 for white noise, and the determinism DET, the fraction of recurrent points that lie on diagonal lines (Marwan et al., 2007). Figure 3 applies the four pictures to a forced double-well Duffing oscillator at three noise levels and to GPT-2 at three sampling temperatures. In both systems the quiet regime is a periodic orbit (for GPT-2, a repetition loop), with sharp spectral peaks and diagonal recurrence lines, and DET falls as the noise or the temperature grows. Over 10 noise seeds and 10 prompts, the median DET is 0.97, 0.48 and 0.42 for the Duffing oscillator and 0.67, 0.32 and 0.17 for GPT-2, and the median H_s is 0.18, 0.60 and 0.90 against 0.70, 0.95 and 0.95. The analogy has a limit that the pictures make plain: the spectra of coherent and of incoherent text are both close to flat, so for GPT-2 these two regimes differ in their recurrence structure and in the level of surprisal, not in the spectrum. Recurrence analysis of hidden states has recently been applied to the reasoning traces of DeepSeek-R1-Distill

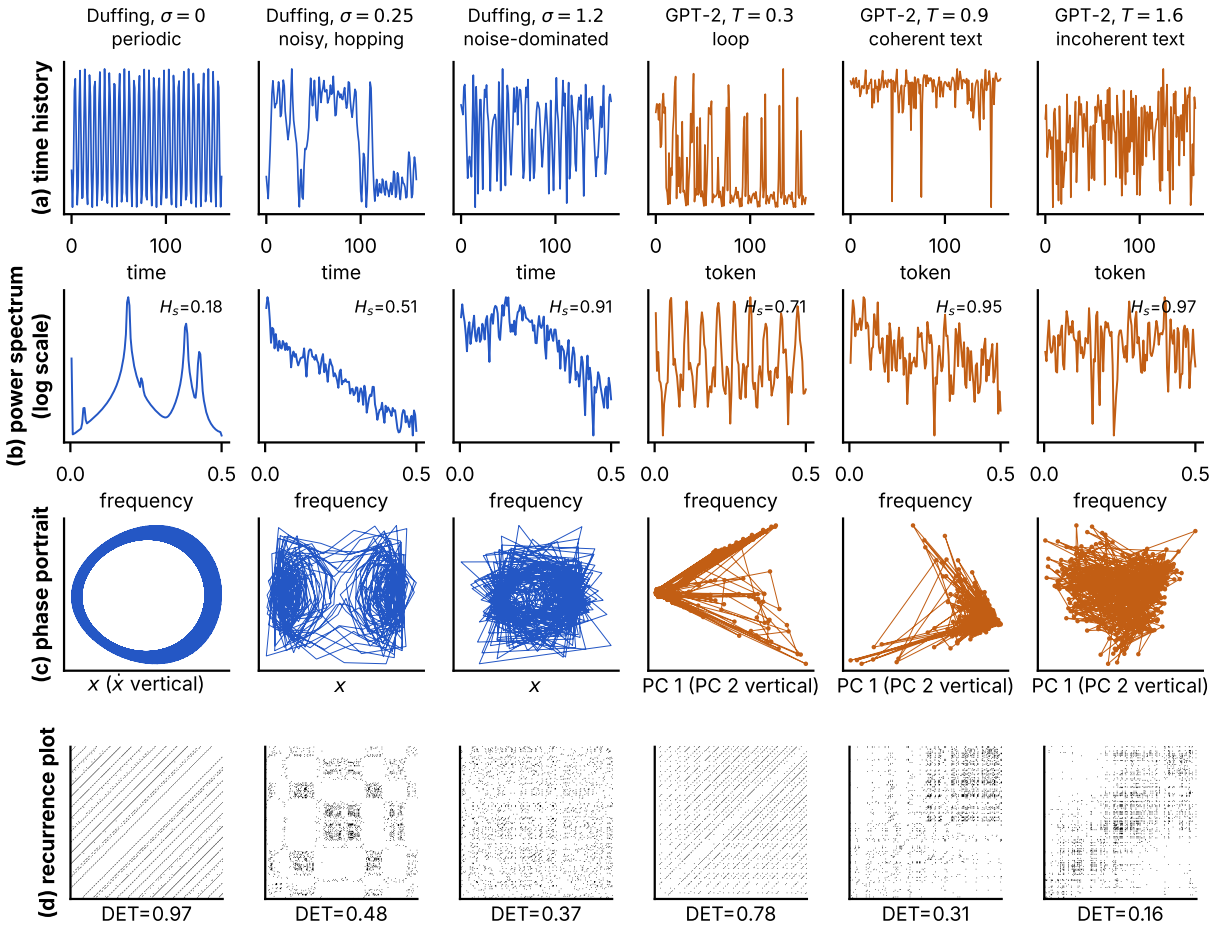


Figure 3: Generation as a dynamical system: the same four pictures for a mechanical oscillator and for a language model. Left: the forced double-well Duffing oscillator $\ddot{x} + 0.25\dot{x} - x + x^3 = 0.1\cos(1.2t) + \sigma\xi(t)$, sampled once per time unit, at noise levels $\sigma = 0$ (periodic orbit in one well), 0.25 (noisy orbits with hops between the wells) and 1.2 (noise-dominated). Right: GPT-2 continuing one prompt for 576 tokens at $T = 0.3$ (a loop of period 19), 0.9 (coherent text) and 1.6 (incoherent text); the state is the final hidden state of each token, scaled to unit norm and standardized per feature, after a transient of 64 tokens. (a) Time history of the first coordinate (x, or the first principal coordinate of the hidden state). (b) Its power spectrum (Welch), with the spectral entropy H_s. (c) Phase portrait: $(x, \dot{x})$, or the first two principal coordinates. (d) Recurrence plot of the full state at a fixed recurrence rate of 5%, with the determinism DET.

(Pham et al., 2026), and recurrence plots and correlation dimensions to chain-of-thought trajectories (Jaca et al., 2026).

Noise-driven escape. Add noise of intensity D to a system resting at the bottom of a well of depth ΔU. The mean time to leave the well grows as

$$\tau \simeq \frac{2\pi}{\omega_0\,\omega_b}\,\gamma\,e^{\Delta U/D} \tag{5}$$

in the overdamped limit with friction γ, where ω_0 and ω_b are set by the curvature at the bottom of the well and at the top of the barrier (Kramers, 1940; Hänggi et al., 1990). The exponential factor is the Arrhenius law for the rate of chemical reactions, with temperature in the role of D (Arrhenius, 1889). In engineering the same question decides whether a ship capsizes in random waves or a structure snaps through

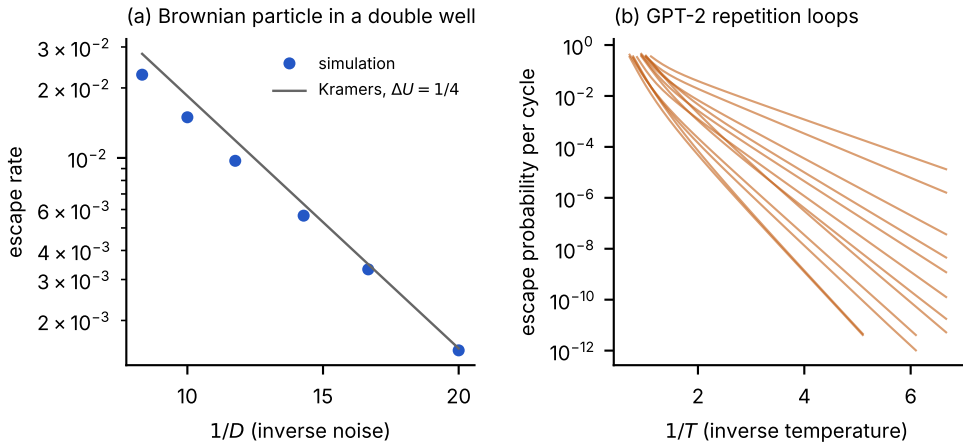


Figure 4: Noise-driven escape in a mechanical system and in a language model, on the same axes. (a) An overdamped particle, $dx = -U'(x)\,dt + \sqrt{2D}\,dW$, in the double well $U(x) = (x^2-1)^2/4$ with barrier $\Delta U = 1/4$: inverse mean first-passage time from $x = -1$ to $x = +1$ (400 particles per noise level) against $1/D$, with Kramers' rate $(\sqrt{2}/2\pi)\,e^{-\Delta U/D}$. The fitted slope gives $\Delta U = 0.23$. (b) Twelve repetition loops of GPT-2 from Experiment 3: exact probability of leaving the loop during one cycle, computed from the stored logits, against $1/T$. At low temperature each curve is a straight line whose slope is the logit gap of the loop, as Proposition 1 predicts (ratio of slope to gap 1.05 to 1.12).

to a buckled state. Escape from potential wells under deterministic periodic forcing is a related problem, where the escape threshold in forcing amplitude depends on the forcing frequency and on the shape of the well (Farid & Gendelman, 2019; Farid, 2022). In mechanics escape is usually the failure to avoid, whereas in text generation the well is a repetition loop and escape is what one wants. We use this lens for SGD in Section 4.2 and for sampling in Section 5.2.

Synchronization and consensus. Weakly coupled oscillators can lock their phases. Bennett et al. (2002) reconstructed Huygens' 1665 observation that two pendulum clocks hanging from a common beam end up swinging in antiphase, the coupling being the small motion of the beam. Metronomes on a board that rolls freely synchronize in the same way (Pantaleone, 2002), and the Moon turns the same face to the Earth because tidal friction locked its rotation to its orbit (Goldreich & Peale, 1966). The Kuramoto model reduces many such systems to phases θ_i with natural frequencies ω_i and coupling strength K,

$$\dot{\theta}_i = \omega_i + \frac{K}{N}\sum_{j=1}^{N}\sin(\theta_j - \theta_i), \tag{6}$$

and shows a transition to collective synchrony once K exceeds a critical value set by the spread of the ω_i (Kuramoto, 1975; Acebrón et al., 2005). Attention over depth has the same structure without the natural frequencies. Each token moves toward an average of the others, weighted by $e^{\beta\langle x_i, x_j\rangle}$, so tokens that are already aligned pull harder on each other (Geshkovski et al., 2023b). On the circle, with $x_i = (\cos\theta_i, \sin\theta_i)$, this gives $\dot{\theta}_i = Z_i^{-1}\sum_j e^{\beta\cos(\theta_j-\theta_i)}\sin(\theta_j-\theta_i)$, a Kuramoto model whose coupling depends on alignment (Li et al., 2026). For $\beta = 0$ all tokens synchronize into one cluster, and for large β several clusters form and persist for a long time before they merge (Section 3).

Koopman linearization. A nonlinear map acts linearly on observables, $g \mapsto g \circ F$ (Koopman, 1931). Eigenfunctions of this Koopman operator give coordinates in which the dynamics is linear, and finite approximations can be learned from data (Mezić, 2005). Dynamic mode decomposition, for instance, extracts the oscillation frequencies and spatial modes of a jet in crossflow directly from snapshots (Rowley et al., 2009). Related data-driven methods learn linear embeddings of nonlinear dynamics with neural networks

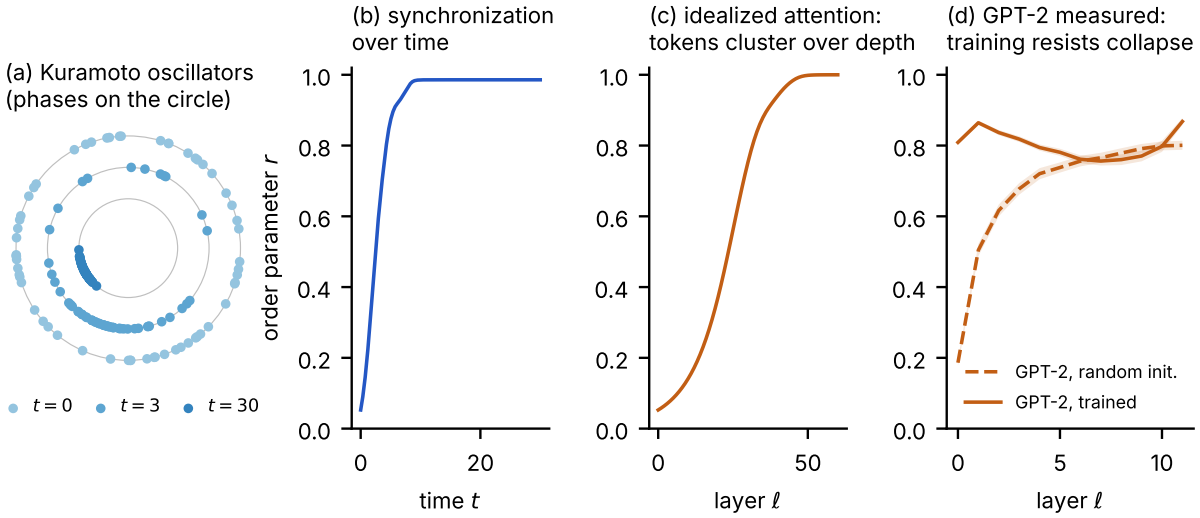


Figure 5: Depth as a dynamical system: synchronization of oscillators and clustering of tokens. (a) Kuramoto model equation 6 with $N = 60$, $K = 1.5$ and $\omega_i \sim \mathcal{N}(0, 0.3^2)$: phases at $t = 0$, 3 and 30 (outer to inner ring). (b) Its order parameter $r = |N^{-1} \sum_j e^{i\theta_j}|$. (c) The attention dynamics on the circle with $\beta = 1$ and 60 tokens: the same order parameter, now over layers. (d) GPT-2, measured: order parameter of the residual stream entering each block, $r_\ell = \|n^{-1} \sum_i x_i^\ell / \|x_i^\ell\|\|$, for 20 prompts (mean ± one standard deviation). With random weights the tokens synchronize over depth as the idealized model predicts (r from 0.19 to 0.80). The trained model starts from aligned embeddings ($r = 0.81$) and stays between 0.76 and 0.87 over the twelve blocks.

(Lusch et al., 2017) or sparse governing equations from data (Brunton et al., 2015). Koopman methods have also been applied to the training dynamics of neural networks (Dogra & Redman, 2020; Redman et al., 2021).

2.3 Why the analogies hold: reduced-order models

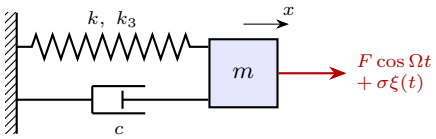
Engineers often understand a complex system through a simple model that shares its governing terms. Sloshing in a partially filled liquid tank is a free-surface flow, yet its response regimes, including the strongly nonlinear ones with hydraulic impacts on the walls, are reproduced by an equivalent mechanical model in which a linear oscillator is coupled to a vibro-impact unit (Farid & Gendelman, 2017). The correspondences shown in Figures 2 to 5 rest on reductions of the same kind. For each one we name the physical model and its governing equation (Figure 6), derive the part of the language model that reduces to it, and state where the reduction stops holding, and Table 1 summarizes the five cases.

The softmax is a Boltzmann distribution. In statistical mechanics a system in contact with a heat bath occupies a state of energy E with probability proportional to $e^{-E/k_B T}$. The sampler equation 3 has exactly this form, with the energy of token y equal to minus its logit, $E_y = -z_y$, and $k_B = 1$. A token is a state, a logit is minus an energy, and the sampling temperature is a temperature in the physical sense. Along a loop the next token a_t has the highest logit, and every other token j is an exit whose energy is higher by $\Delta_t^j = z_{a_t} - z_j$. The probability of leaving at step t is

$$1 - p_t(T) = \frac{\sum_{j \neq a_t} e^{-\Delta_t^j / T}}{1 + \sum_{j \neq a_t} e^{-\Delta_t^j / T}} \approx m_t \, e^{-\Delta_t / T} \qquad (T \to 0), \tag{7}$$

where Δ_t is the smallest gap and m_t the number of tokens that attain it. This is the Arrhenius factor of Kramers' problem equation 5, with the logit gap in place of the barrier height ΔU and T in place of the

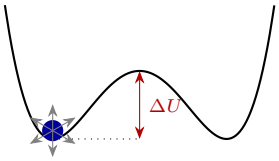
(a) Duffing oscillator



$m\ddot{x} + c\dot{x} + kx + k_3x^3 = F\cos\Omega t + \sigma\xi(t)$

$k < 0 < k_3$: two wells. Language model: a well is a loop, the noise is the sampling temperature (Fig. 3).

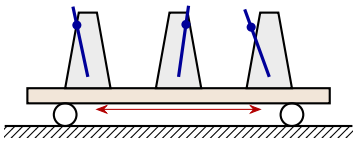
(b) Brownian particle in a well



$\gamma\dot{x} = -U'(x) + \sqrt{2\gamma D}\,\xi(t), \quad \text{rate} \propto e^{-\Delta U/D}$

Language model: leaving a loop, $\Delta U \leftrightarrow$ logit gap Δ, $D \leftrightarrow T$, exact by the softmax (Prop. 1, Fig. 4).

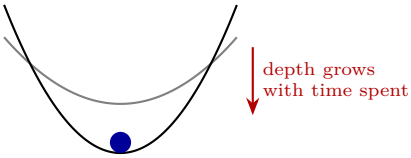
(c) Metronomes on a rolling board



$\dot{\theta}_i = \omega_i + \frac{K}{N}\sum_j \sin(\theta_j - \theta_i)$

Language model: tokens over depth, coupled by attention; on the circle attention is this equation with $\omega_i = 0$ (Eq. 9).

(d) A well that deepens while occupied



$\Delta_c = \Delta_\infty - (\Delta_\infty - \Delta_1)\,e^{-(c-1)/\tau}$

Language model: the repeated text in the context deepens the loop; reduced model of Section 2.3 (Fig. 7).

Figure 6: Physical models used in this paper, with their governing equations and the behavior of a language model that each one reduces. (a) A mass on a spring with linear stiffness k and cubic stiffness k_3, damping c, harmonic forcing and noise; with $k < 0$ the potential $\frac{1}{2}kx^2 + \frac{1}{4}k_3x^4$ has two wells. (b) An overdamped particle in a potential well under thermal noise of intensity D, whose escape rate over the barrier ΔU is given by Kramers' formula equation 5. (c) Metronomes on a board that can roll, which synchronize through the small motion of the board; their phases follow the Kuramoto model equation 6. (d) A well whose depth grows with the time the particle has spent in it and then saturates.

Table 1: Reduced-order models of language-model behavior. The shared term is the part of the governing equation that produces the behavior in both systems.

Language model	Reduced model	Shared term	Status
Escape from a loop (clock 3)	Particle in a well under noise, Fig. 6(b)	Boltzmann factor: $e^{-\Delta/T}$ and $e^{-\Delta U/D}$	Exact identity (Prop. 1)
Period two at the edge of stability (clock 2)	Explicit Euler step on a nonlinear spring	Step multiplier $1 - \eta\lambda$ crossing -1, cubic term of the loss	Derived; multi-mode edge not covered
Clustering over depth (clock 1)	Kuramoto oscillators, Fig. 6(c)	Coupling $\sin(\theta_j - \theta_i)$	Exact for idealized attention; trained GPT-2 departs
Loops that hold for a while (clock 3)	Particle in a deepening well, Fig. 6(d)	Barrier that grows with residence time	Fitted; $T_{1/2}$ within 9% to 25%
Regimes of generation (clock 3)	Noisy double-well Duffing oscillator, Fig. 6(a)	Ratio of barrier to noise	Same ordering, measured

noise intensity D (Figure 6b). The correspondence is an identity, which is why every loop in Figure 4(b) gives a straight line whose slope is its gap. Two differences remain. A Brownian particle diffuses up to the barrier, and the curvatures at the bottom and the top of the well set Kramers' prefactor; the sampler jumps in one step, so the prefactor is the number of exits m_t. In addition, the energies of a language model change as the context grows, which we treat below.

Gradient descent is an Euler step on a nonlinear spring. Gradient descent $\theta_{t+1} = \theta_t - \eta\nabla\mathcal{L}(\theta_t)$ is the explicit Euler scheme with step η for the gradient flow $\dot{\theta} = -\nabla\mathcal{L}(\theta)$, the motion of an overdamped particle in the potential $\mathcal{L}$. Restrict it to the eigenvector u of the largest Hessian eigenvalue λ at a minimum

θ^*, with $x = \langle \theta - \theta^*, u \rangle$ and $\ell(x) = \mathcal{L}(\theta^* + xu)$. Then

$$x_{t+1} = x_t - \eta\, \ell'(x_t), \qquad \ell'(x) = \lambda x + \tfrac{1}{2}\ell'''x^2 + \tfrac{1}{6}\ell''''x^3 + \dots, \tag{8}$$

and $-\ell'(x)$ is the restoring force of a spring with linear, quadratic and cubic stiffness, the Duffing spring of Figure 6(a) when the quadratic term vanishes. The linear term alone gives $x_{t+1} = (1 - \eta\lambda)x_t$, whose multiplier crosses -1 at $\eta\lambda = 2$. The minimum then loses stability through a period-doubling bifurcation, the same instability that limits the time step of the explicit Euler scheme for a stiff spring. The nonlinear terms decide what follows. For the double well $\ell(x) = (x^2 - 1)^2/4$ around $x = 1$, where $\lambda = 2$, the iterate settles on a period-2 orbit for $\eta\lambda$ between 2 and about 2.47, on a period-4 orbit from 2.48, on a period-8 orbit near 2.58, and on no orbit of period up to 64 from about 2.62 (Figure 2a,b). A period-2 orbit is what produces the spectral line at frequency 1/2. A network adds a third ingredient: λ depends on θ, so the oscillation along u changes the curvature that drives it. Damian et al. (2022) reduce this feedback to the two-variable map equation 13, in which the cubic term of the loss lowers the sharpness whenever the oscillation grows. The feedback explains why the transformer of Experiment 2 shows a line at 1/2 (Figure 2c,f) across two decades of step size instead of a cascade to chaos at one step size: training keeps its own bifurcation parameter at the threshold. The one-direction reduction holds while one eigenvalue dominates. In our transformer two to six eigenvalues sit above $2/\eta$ (Section 7.2), which neither equation 8 nor the two-variable map describes.

Attention on the circle is a Kuramoto model. In the transformer model of Geshkovski et al. (2023b), layer normalization keeps every token on the unit sphere, and self-attention with identity query, key and value matrices moves token i by

$$\dot{x}_i = P_{x_i}\Big(Z_i^{-1} \sum_j e^{\beta\langle x_i, x_j\rangle} x_j\Big), \qquad Z_i = \sum_j e^{\beta\langle x_i, x_j\rangle},$$

where P_x projects onto the tangent space of the sphere at x. In two dimensions write $x_i = (\cos\theta_i, \sin\theta_i)$. The unit tangent at x_i is $(-\sin\theta_i, \cos\theta_i)$, its inner product with x_j is $\sin(\theta_j - \theta_i)$, and $\langle x_i, x_j\rangle = \cos(\theta_j - \theta_i)$, so

$$\dot{\theta}_i = Z_i^{-1} \sum_j e^{\beta\cos(\theta_j - \theta_i)} \sin(\theta_j - \theta_i). \tag{9}$$

For $\beta = 0$, $Z_i = N$ and equation 9 is the Kuramoto model equation 6 with $\omega_i = 0$ and $K = 1$, the model of identical metronomes on a common board, which synchronize from almost every initial condition (Figure 6c). In both systems each unit is pulled toward a weighted average of the others, and for $\beta > 0$ the pull is stronger between tokens that are already close, which lets several clusters form and persist (Section 3). The reduction accounts for Figure 5(c) and for GPT-2 with random weights in panel (d). Trained GPT-2 departs from it: its order parameter stays near 0.8 over all twelve blocks. The reduction drops the learned query, key and value maps, the MLP blocks and the finite depth. One candidate explanation is that these terms act like the spread of natural frequencies ω_i in the Kuramoto model, which opposes synchronization; we have not tested it.

A repetition loop is a well that deepens while it is occupied. The Boltzmann identity equation 7 holds at every step, but the energies change from cycle to cycle, because each completed cycle adds the same text to the context and the model grows more confident that it will repeat it. Figure 7(a) shows the smallest gap Δ_c of each cycle along three GPT-2 loops: it grows and then saturates. The physical counterpart is a particle in a well that deepens while it is occupied (Figure 6d). Rock friction behaves this way: the static friction between two surfaces grows with the time they have been in contact (Dieterich, 1972), so a block that has rested longer needs a larger force to slide. The reduced model has two ingredients, a saturating barrier fitted to the gaps of each loop,

$$\Delta_c = \Delta_\infty - (\Delta_\infty - \Delta_1)\, e^{-(c-1)/\tau}, \qquad r_c(T) = 1 - \big(1 + e^{-\Delta_c/T}\big)^{-\nu}, \tag{10}$$

and an escape probability per cycle r_c for a single exit attempted ν times per cycle. The three numbers $\Delta_1, \Delta_\infty, \tau$ of each loop come from its greedy run alone, and ν plays the role of Kramers' prefactor; we use one value per model, chosen on a grid ($\nu = 3$ for GPT-2, $\nu = 4$ for Pythia-160M). Figure 7 compares the locking

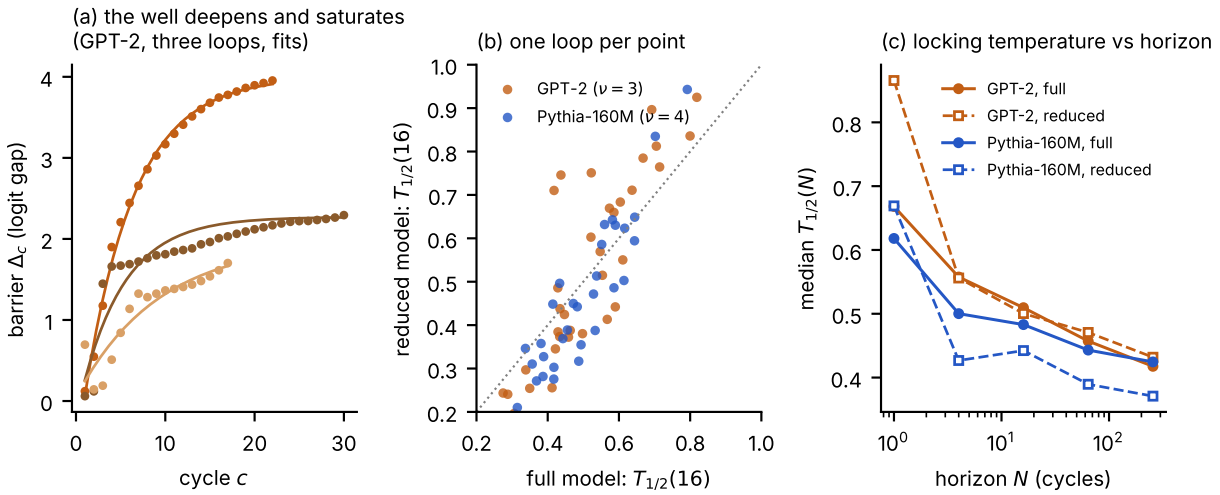


Figure 7: The reduced-order model of loop escape against the full computation. (a) Smallest logit gap of each cycle (dots) along three GPT-2 loops of at least 15 cycles, with the saturating fit of equation 10 (lines). (b) Locking temperature for a horizon of 16 cycles after a burn-in of two cycles, from the reduced model (three numbers per loop read from the greedy run, one attempt number ν per model) against the full computation from all logits, one point per loop. (c) Median locking temperature against the horizon for both models, full (filled) and reduced (open).

temperature $T_{1/2}(N)$ of this model with the full computation from all logits of all steps (Section 7.3). For horizons of 4 to 256 cycles the reduced model is within a median of 9% to 25% of the full value for individual loops, with correlations of 0.74 to 0.95 across loops, and it reproduces the slow fall of $T_{1/2}$ with N. For a single cycle it is off by 30% to 50%. For long horizons the reduced model gives $T_{1/2}(N) \approx \Delta_\infty / \ln(\nu N / \ln 2)$, the form of equation 17, since an escape within N cycles becomes likely once $\nu N e^{-\Delta_\infty / T}$ is of order one, so the locking temperature falls like $1/\ln N$.

Generation regimes follow the ratio of barrier to noise. The same ratio organizes the three regimes of Figure 3. For the double-well Duffing oscillator with unit mass, damping c and noise amplitude σ, the unforced motion has the stationary density $\propto \exp\{-(\dot{x}^2/2 + U(x))/D\}$ with $D = \sigma^2/(2c)$, so the depth of a well in units of the noise is $\Delta U/D$, with $\Delta U = 1/4$ for $U = -x^2/2 + x^4/4$. If an escape has probability of order $e^{-\Delta U/D}$ per period, the oscillator is expected to leave a well within N periods once $\Delta U/D \lesssim \ln(N/\ln 2)$. Above this value it stays on a periodic orbit in one well, near it it hops between wells, and far below it the noise dominates. For a loop of a language model the corresponding ratio is Δ/T, with Δ the barrier of the loop, and the same estimate gives $\Delta/T \lesssim \ln(\nu N/\ln 2)$, with N the number of cycles in the window. Figure 8 plots the determinism of the trajectory against this ratio for both systems. For the oscillator (512 samples, about 98 forcing periods, so $\ln(N/\ln 2) \approx 4.9$) DET rises from 0.38 to 0.78 as $\Delta U/D$ grows from 0.09 to 50, with its largest step between 3.1 and 5.6. For GPT-2 we sampled five prompts whose greedy runs loop, at eight temperatures from 0.3 to 1.4, and took Δ as the gap of the last cycles of the greedy loop. DET rises with Δ/T (correlation 0.75 with $\log(\Delta/T)$ over 40 runs), and the binned median climbs from 0.37 to 0.82 between $\Delta/T \approx 5.6$ and 12, just above the value 4.9 at which one escape is expected in the window. The scatter between prompts is large, and five prompts do not determine the shape of the curve, but both systems leave the periodic regime when the barrier falls to a few times the noise, at the value set by the length of the observation.

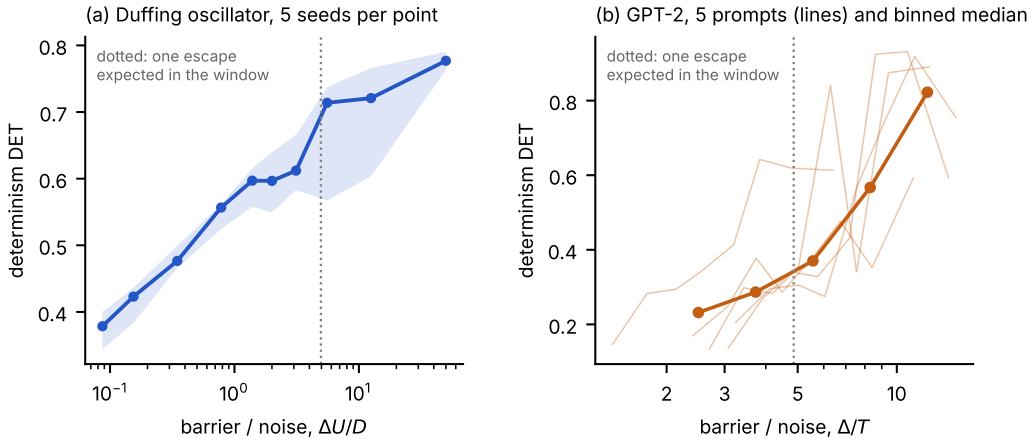


Figure 8: Determinism of the trajectory against the ratio of barrier height to noise intensity. (a) Forced double-well Duffing oscillator of Figure 3, ten noise levels, five seeds each (median and range), with $D = \sigma^2/(2c)$ and $\Delta U = 1/4$. (b) GPT-2, five prompts whose greedy runs end in a loop, sampled at eight temperatures from 0.3 to 1.4; Δ is the median logit gap of the last three cycles of the greedy loop. Thin lines: individual prompts; thick line: median in bins of Δ/T. Dotted lines: the ratio at which one escape is expected within the observed window, $\ln(N/\ln 2)$ for the oscillator and $\ln(\nu N/\ln 2)$ with $\nu = 3$ for GPT-2.

3 Clock 1: depth as time

3.1 Residual networks as discretized flows

Equation equation 1 is a forward Euler step of an ODE $\dot{x} = f(x, \ell)$ with unit step. This observation was made early for residual networks (He et al., 2015) by E (2017), Haber & Ruthotto (2017) and Lu et al. (2017), and it led to continuous-depth models (Chen et al., 2018), to architectures designed from the stability theory of ODEs and PDEs (Haber & Ruthotto, 2017; Ruthotto & Haber, 2018; Chang et al., 2019), to invertible second-order variants (Sander et al., 2021a), and to a view of training as optimal control (E et al., 2018). Whether a trained residual network actually converges to an ODE as depth grows depends on the initialization and on how the residual branch is scaled (Sander et al., 2022). In transformers, several stabilization methods amount to a choice of this step size, either by scaling the residual branch at initialization (Bachlechner et al., 2020; Wang et al., 2022) or by moving the layer normalization inside the branch (Xiong et al., 2020; Liu et al., 2020).

3.2 Attention as an interacting particle system

The transformer differs from a plain residual network because the update of token i depends on all tokens. Lu et al. (2019) read a transformer layer as a splitting scheme for a convection-diffusion equation of interacting particles. Sander et al. (2021b) showed that attention with doubly stochastic normalization is a Wasserstein gradient flow. Geshkovski et al. (2023a;b) studied a model in which tokens live on the unit sphere (a stand-in for layer normalization) and follow

$$\dot{x}_i = P_{x_i}\Big(\frac{1}{Z_i}\sum_j e^{\beta\langle Qx_i, Kx_j\rangle} V x_j\Big), \tag{11}$$

where P_x projects onto the tangent space and β acts as an inverse temperature. They proved that, for broad choices of Q, K, V, the tokens cluster as time (depth) grows, in the simplest cases to a single point. Clustering is the particle-system version of an older observation: stacks of pure attention lose rank doubly exponentially with depth (Dong et al., 2021), and rank collapse at initialization slows training (Noci et al., 2022). Similar results hold for oversmoothing in attention-based graph networks, which Wu et al. (2023) analyze as nonlinear time-varying dynamical systems.

Later work moved the model closer to real decoders. With causal masking the particle system is no longer a mean-field gradient flow, but clustering results still hold, and the first token, which attends only to itself, plays a special role (Karagodin et al., 2024). Wu et al. (2024) showed that the attention mask and layer normalization decide whether collapse happens at all. A mean-field limit with a Vlasov-type "Transformer PDE" covers several attention variants (Castin et al., 2025). Feed-forward layers can be read as a control that steers the particles (Maranzatto et al., 2026). Finite-width transformers with MLP blocks converge to a stochastic interacting particle system, in which noise can synchronize the tokens (Agazzi et al., 2026). For symmetric weights a spectral mode-selection mechanism decides the long-time state (Kuehn & Yoon, 2026), and in two dimensions deep linear transformers reduce to Kuramoto-type models with a rich set of behaviors (Li et al., 2026). The kinetic theory of causal attention has also been used to explain why models use the middle of long contexts poorly (Duerinckx et al., 2026), the lost-in-the-middle effect of Liu et al. (2023).

Real models have finite depth, so the long-time limit of equation 11 describes them only partly. Geshkovski et al. (2024) proved that particles stay near a configuration of several clusters for an exponentially long time before they merge, and a stack of finite depth spends its layers inside such a long-lived transient.

3.3 Signal propagation, order and chaos

A second line of work treats a randomly initialized deep network as a random dynamical system and asks whether small input differences grow or shrink with depth. Poole et al. (2016) found an order-to-chaos transition controlled by the weight and bias variances σ_w^2, σ_b^2. For a wide fully connected network with nonlinearity ϕ, the correlation between two nearby inputs is multiplied at each layer by

$$\chi_1 = \sigma_w^2 \int \mathcal{D}z \left[\phi'(\sqrt{q^*}\, z)\right]^2, \tag{12}$$

where q^* is the fixed point of the length map and $\mathcal{D}z$ is the standard Gaussian measure. Inputs converge for $\chi_1 < 1$ (order) and separate for $\chi_1 > 1$ (chaos), so $\ln \chi_1$ plays the role of a Lyapunov exponent per layer; Schoenholz et al. (2016) showed that the depth over which signals propagate diverges at the transition, so networks are trainable to large depth only near it. The idea goes back to the chaotic phase of random recurrent networks (Sompolinsky et al., 1988). Requiring all singular values of the input-output Jacobian to be close to one (dynamical isometry) gives faster training still (Pennington et al., 2017) and allowed 10,000-layer convolutional networks to train (Xiao et al., 2018). For transformers, Cowsik et al. (2024) track the geometry of n token representations as a discrete-time system of interacting particles and derive conditions on the initialization that make deep transformers trainable.

For trained networks, Storm et al. (2023) computed finite-time Lyapunov exponents equation 4 of fully connected classifiers and found ridges of large exponents in input space that separate the classes, much like coherent structures in fluid flows. Our first experiment (Section 7.1) applies the same quantity to the residual stream of language models across training.

3.4 Trajectories in trained language models

Interpretability research gives a complementary, empirical picture of the depth dynamics in trained models. Predictions decoded from intermediate layers improve gradually, which suggests iterative refinement (Belrose et al., 2023). Deleting or swapping middle layers hurts much less than touching the first or last ones, consistent with distinct stages of inference (Lad et al., 2024). The intrinsic dimension of hidden representations rises and then falls across layers (Valeriani et al., 2023). Token trajectories through depth cluster along a low-dimensional manifold and can be modeled as a stochastic process with few parameters (Sarfati et al., 2024). Fernando & Guitchounts (2025) treat the residual stream with tools from neural population dynamics and report that individual units change smoothly from layer to layer; Fernando & Guitchounts (2026) compute full Jacobian eigendecompositions of each layer in production-scale models. A small number of activations are orders of magnitude larger than the rest and nearly independent of the input (Sun et al., 2024); together with attention sinks (Xiao et al., 2023), they can be read as a near fixed point of the depth dynamics. Methods that read features off the layer Jacobian have also been analyzed theoretically (Ostrow et al., 2026). Recurrent-depth or looped models make the iteration explicit by applying the same block repeatedly, and their stability can be studied and scaled as such (Prairie et al., 2026).

3.5 When depth imitates training

Clock 1 can emulate clock 2. For in-context regression, a linear self-attention layer can implement one step of gradient descent on the in-context examples, so a stack of layers runs an optimizer whose iterations are the layers (von Oswald et al., 2022; Akyürek et al., 2022; Garg et al., 2022); trained linear transformers learn preconditioned versions of this algorithm (Ahn et al., 2023), and the gradient-flow dynamics that produce them can be solved in closed form (Zhang et al., 2023b). In this regime layer time is optimization time, and the step-size and stability questions of clock 2 carry over to clock 1.

3.6 Lessons from recurrent networks

Recurrent networks are the older case in which clocks 1 and 3 coincide: the same map is applied at every time step. Their analysis set many of the patterns used later for transformers. Fixed points and slow points of trained networks explain how they compute (Sussillo & Barak, 2013), and sentiment classifiers turn out to integrate evidence along a line attractor (Maheswaranathan et al., 2019). On the training side, exploding gradients were linked to bifurcations of the network dynamics (Pascanu et al., 2012; Ribeiro et al., 2019), and networks trained to reproduce chaotic dynamics must have diverging gradients (Mikhaeil et al., 2021). Lyapunov spectra quantify how much information a recurrent network keeps (Engelken et al., 2020; Vogt et al., 2020).

3.7 Explicit dynamical models of sequences

State-space models write the sequence dynamics in clock 3 explicitly, as a linear dynamical system in a hidden state, with eigenvalues placed to control memory and stability (Gu et al., 2021; Orvieto et al., 2023), or with input-dependent transitions (Gu & Dao, 2023). Linear attention has the same structure: it is a recurrent update of a matrix-valued state (Katharopoulos et al., 2020; Schlag et al., 2021). Recurrent networks built from coupled oscillators or constrained by Lipschitz bounds use the same design logic (Rusch & Mishra, 2020; Erichson et al., 2020). In these models the attractor and stability questions of this paper are explicit, since the eigenvalues of the state transition are parameters of the architecture.

4 Clock 2: training as a dynamical system

4.1 Gradient descent at the edge of stability

Classical optimization theory treats gradient descent as a discretization of gradient flow, which is valid when the step size is small compared with the inverse curvature. Cohen et al. (2021) showed that neural network training does not stay in that regime. Under full-batch gradient descent the sharpness, meaning the largest Hessian eigenvalue $\lambda_{\max}$, first rises (progressive sharpening) until it reaches $2/\eta$, and then hovers near that value while the loss keeps decreasing in a non-monotone way. By the linear stability argument of Section 2.2, the iteration then sits on the boundary where the top direction loses stability. Adaptive methods show the same behavior with respect to the preconditioned sharpness (Cohen et al., 2022).

Several mechanisms have been proposed for why training survives at this boundary. Damian et al. (2022) show that the third-order term of the loss creates a negative feedback: when the iterate oscillates along the top eigenvector, the oscillation itself reduces the sharpness. In their reduced model, x_t is the displacement along the top eigenvector u and y_t is the excess of the sharpness over $2/\eta$, measured along ∇S, and the two evolve as

$$x_{t+1} = -(1 + \eta y_t)\, x_t, \qquad y_{t+1} = y_t + \eta\big(\alpha - \beta x_t^2\big), \tag{13}$$

where $\alpha > 0$ measures progressive sharpening and $\beta = \|\nabla S\|^2$. The oscillation grows while $y_t > 0$ and its square pulls y_t back, so the pair cycles around the edge instead of diverging. Arora et al. (2022) and Ahn et al. (2022) give conditions under which gradient descent converges while being locally unstable. Minimal models help because they can be solved: Zhu et al. (2022) find edge-of-stability dynamics in a two-parameter example, and Chen & Bruna (2022) show that beyond the threshold gradient descent can converge to stable period-two orbits, a period-doubling bifurcation in the strict sense. Backward error analysis of the finite step

shows that gradient descent follows a modified flow with an implicit penalty on the gradient norm (Barrett & Dherin, 2020).

Larger step sizes push the map further. Lewkowycz et al. (2020) identified a catapult phase in which the loss first grows, the curvature drops, and training settles in a flatter region; above a second threshold training diverges. Kalra & Barkeshli (2023) mapped the early-training regimes as a function of learning rate, depth and width. Kong & Tao (2020) showed that deterministic gradient descent on a multiscale objective, with a step size that resolves only the macroscopic scale, can become chaotic and converge to a statistical distribution. Tuci et al. (2026) model stochastic optimizers at the edge of stability as random dynamical systems with fractal attractors and relate the attractor dimension to generalization. Sohl-Dickstein (2024) found that the boundary in hyperparameter space between step sizes that train and those that diverge is fractal, in the same way as the boundary of bounded orbits of the quadratic map that defines the Mandelbrot set. Mini-batch sampling moves this stability boundary even when gradients are unbiased, as shown exactly for linear self-attention (Balasubramanian, 2026). Curvature control has been used to keep large transformers away from the boundary (Ramasinghe et al., 2026; Gilmer et al., 2021).

A continuous-time description of the whole edge-of-stability regime is now available. The central flow of Cohen et al. (2024) is an ODE for the time-averaged trajectory that keeps the sharpness at $2/\eta$ and predicts the loss curve of real networks, and Berthier (2026) derives it by a formal expansion in three time scales with the method of multiple scales. Marion (2026) proposes a related three-variable flow for the center, direction and amplitude of the oscillation. Bifurcation theory gives the local picture. Song & Yun (2023) prove that in simple models trajectories align on a bifurcation diagram, Gan (2026) treats the onset of oscillation as a flip bifurcation of the normal dynamics near a manifold of minimizers, and Mulayoff & Stich (2026) give an exact criterion, in terms of third and fourth derivatives, for when oscillations near a minimum are stable. Litman (2026) shows that a weighted average of the curvature along the steps is forced to $2/\eta$. Why the sharpness rises in the first place, progressive sharpening, is proved only in reduced models (Agarwala et al., 2022), and the route from the edge to chaos at larger steps has been mapped in a two-layer linear model (Kalra et al., 2023). Section 7.2 adds a measurement to this picture: in a small transformer the edge is multi-mode, with several eigenvalues above $2/\eta$, while the curvature along the step equals $2/\eta$.

4.2 Stochastic gradient descent as a noisy dynamical system

Minibatch noise turns clock 2 into a stochastic process. Stochastic modified equations approximate SGD with step size η and batch size B by the SDE

$$d\theta = -\nabla \mathcal{L}(\theta)\, dt + \sqrt{\tfrac{\eta}{B}\, C(\theta)}\, dW_t, \tag{14}$$

where C is the covariance of per-example gradients and time is measured in units of η (Li et al., 2015). Near a minimum with Hessian H the drift is linear, the process is of Ornstein-Uhlenbeck type, and its stationary covariance Σ solves the Lyapunov equation $H\Sigma + \Sigma H = (\eta/B)\, C$, so the ratio η/B acts as a temperature (Mandt et al., 2017; Smith & Le, 2017; Jastrzębski et al., 2017). Because SGD noise is anisotropic and state dependent, the stationary distribution is not a Gibbs distribution of the training loss, and the dynamics can converge to limit cycles instead of points (Chaudhari & Soatto, 2017).

Escape from a minimum is the most direct use of the escape theory sketched in Section 2.2. Xie et al. (2020) derived a Kramers-type rate for SGD and found that, unlike isotropic Langevin dynamics, SGD favors flat minima exponentially in the ratio of barrier height to Hessian eigenvalues. Anisotropic noise aligned with the curvature helps escape from sharp minima (Zhu et al., 2018). Mori et al. (2021) showed that the multiplicative character of the noise changes the law: the escape rate depends on the logarithm of the loss barrier, which gives an escape rate that scales as a power of the loss ratio between saddle and minimum. Heavy-tailed gradient noise points toward Lévy-driven escape, which is dominated by single large jumps (Simsekli et al., 2019). The precise law therefore depends on the noise model, and the law that holds for language model pretraining has not been measured.

4.3 Saddles, plateaus and ghosts

High-dimensional loss surfaces have far more saddles than local minima (Dauphin et al., 2014). Noise or small perturbations let gradient methods leave strict saddles efficiently (Ge et al., 2015; Jin et al., 2017), but the time spent near a saddle can still dominate training. For deep linear networks the learning dynamics can be solved exactly: modes of the input-output map are learned one after another, separated by plateaus whose length depends on the initialization (Saxe et al., 2013). Spectral bias and the frequency principle describe a similar ordering, with low-frequency components learned first (Rahaman et al., 2018; Xu et al., 2019). In recurrent networks, abrupt learning after a long plateau has been traced to the ghost of a saddle-node bifurcation (Dinc et al., 2025), and learning can itself drive a network from chaotic to stable activity (Vaidya, 2026).

4.4 Abrupt transitions in what the model can do

Grokking, where test accuracy jumps long after the training loss has saturated, was first reported on algorithmic data (Power et al., 2022). Inside the network the change is gradual: circuit-level measures improve steadily before the jump (Nanda et al., 2023). Explanations include an effective theory of representation learning with a phase diagram (Liu et al., 2022a), a dependence on weight norm (Liu et al., 2022b), a transition from lazy to rich training (Kumar et al., 2023), two phases of implicit bias (Lyu et al., 2023), and a first-order phase transition in a solvable two-layer model (Rubin et al., 2023). With adaptive optimizers, grokking coincides with cyclic phase changes and loss spikes (Thilak et al., 2022).

Language models show similar transitions. Induction heads form during a short window of training, and the loss curve shows a visible bump at that moment (Olsson et al., 2022). Syntactic attention structure appears abruptly and is followed by a drop in loss (Chen et al., 2023). In-context learning can emerge and later fade while training continues (Singh et al., 2023); minimal models explain the abruptness (Reddy, 2023), and Bayesian models of attention predict phase transitions in the emergence of copy heads (Lavie et al., 2026). Singular learning theory relates these stages to changes in the degeneracy of the loss landscape (Hoogland et al., 2024). Across model scale, abilities can appear suddenly (Wei et al., 2022), although part of the effect comes from discontinuous metrics (Schaeffer et al., 2023); one model attributes emergence to discrete skills that are learned in order of frequency (Michaud et al., 2023).

4.5 Loss spikes in large-scale pretraining

Large pretraining runs show sudden loss spikes. PaLM handled them by restarting from an earlier checkpoint and skipping data (Chowdhery et al., 2022). Wortsman et al. (2023) reproduced two instability mechanisms at small scale, growth of attention logits and divergence of the output logits, and studied how they depend on learning rate. Attention entropy collapse is another proposed cause (Zhai et al., 2023), as is the behavior of the Adam update at large scale (Molybog et al., 2023); conditions on the scale of embeddings and residual connections can prevent spikes (Takase et al., 2023). The smallest model with a loss spike has two parameters. In the catapult model of Lewkowycz et al. (2020), $f = uv$ is fit to a single target with step size η, and the curvature of the valley of minima at (u, v) is $u^2 + v^2$. Started where this curvature exceeds $2/\eta$, gradient descent raises the loss tenfold within two steps, throws the iterate out of the sharp part of the valley, and settles where the curvature is below $2/\eta$, after which the loss decays (Figure 9). From the dynamical point of view these are instabilities of the map equation 2 near the edge of stability, and the open question is which kind (Section 8, **OP 4**).

4.6 Slow phases, landscape geometry and conserved quantities

Pretraining curves typically show a fast initial drop followed by a long slow phase. Zhang et al. (2026a) observe that the normalized singular value spectrum of the weight matrices stabilizes early and that this stabilization coincides with the slow phase. The river-valley picture explains why a constant learning rate followed by a fast decay works: the iterate moves along a valley floor while oscillating across it (Wen et al., 2024). The Hessian has a bulk of near-zero eigenvalues and a few outliers (Sagun et al., 2017; Ghorbani et al., 2019), and the gradient lies mostly in the subspace of the outliers (Gur-Ari et al., 2018). Two copies

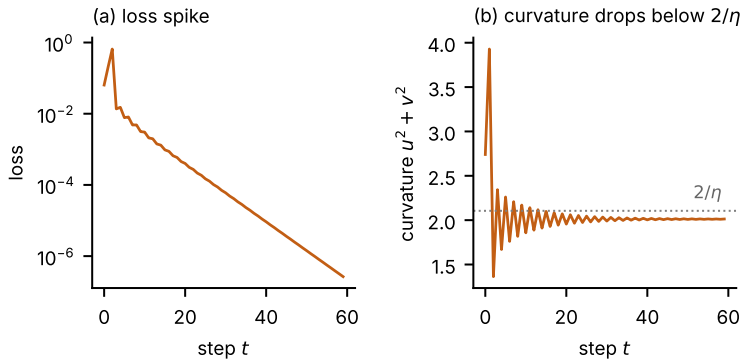


Figure 9: A loss spike in two parameters. Gradient descent on $(uv - 1)^2/2$ with $\eta = 0.95$, started near $(u, v) = (1.6, 0.4)$ where the curvature of the valley of minima, $u^2 + v^2 = 2.74$, exceeds $2/\eta = 2.11$. (a) The loss jumps from 0.064 to 0.66 and then decays. (b) The curvature oscillates and settles at 2.01, below $2/\eta$.

of a run that are split at step k and then see different minibatch noise end in the same linearly connected region only when k is past a short early phase; before that, the trajectory is sensitive to small perturbations (Frankle et al., 2019). Continuous symmetries of the architecture imply conservation laws for gradient flow, which finite steps and noise break in predictable ways (Kunin et al., 2020). At the end of classification training, features converge to a highly symmetric configuration (Papyan et al., 2020).

Infinite-width limits give two simpler dynamical systems. In the lazy limit, training is linear in function space (Jacot et al., 2018). In the mean-field limit, training two-layer networks is a Wasserstein gradient flow of particles (Mei et al., 2018; Chizat & Bach, 2018), and parametrizations exist that keep feature learning at infinite width (Yang & Hu, 2020). Scaling laws describe the slow phase at the level of loss averaged over the whole run (Kaplan et al., 2020; Hoffmann et al., 2022). Koopman operator methods have been used to speed up training and to explain magnitude pruning (Dogra & Redman, 2020; Redman et al., 2021).

5 Clock 3: generation as a dynamical system

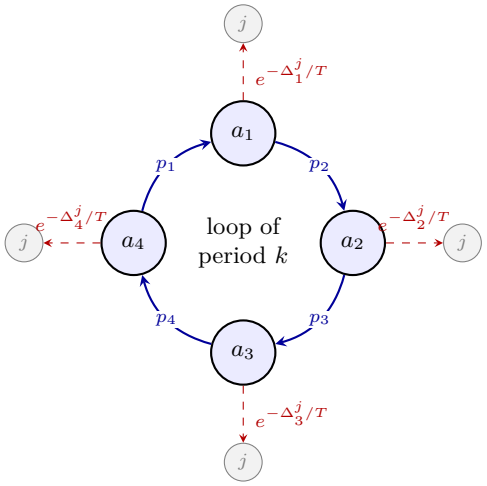
5.1 Decoding as a stochastic map

Definition 3 makes generation a Markov chain whose state is the whole context. The state space grows with n, so the usual results on stationary distributions do not apply directly, but the questions of dynamical systems still make sense: which sets of contexts trap the chain, how long the chain stays in them, and how these answers depend on the temperature T and on truncation. Krishnamurthy et al. (2026) formulate language models as high-dimensional nonlinear autoregressive models and analyze networks of interacting models with mean-field equations. A deterministic version of clock 3, obtained by feeding back the expected embedding of the next-token distribution instead of a sample, is a continuous map that can be analyzed with standard tools (Jones, 2026).

Temperature divides the logits by T, so π_T in equation 3 is a Gibbs distribution with energy $-z$ at temperature T. Greedy decoding is the limit $T \to 0$, and T sets how often the chain leaves the most likely path, so it serves as both the noise intensity and the natural bifurcation parameter of clock 3. Its effect on task accuracy (Renze & Guven, 2024) and on novelty and coherence (Peeperkorn et al., 2024) has been measured directly.

5.2 Repetition loops as attractors

With greedy or low-temperature decoding, models fall into loops that repeat a phrase or sentence until the length limit (Holtzman et al., 2019). At $T = 0$ the chain is deterministic and the loop is one of its periodic orbits. Xu et al. (2022) showed that loops reinforce themselves: the probability of repeating a sentence



$$p_t(T) = \frac{1}{1 + \sum_{j \neq a_t} e^{-\Delta_t^j/T}}$$

escape per cycle: $r(T) = 1 - \prod_{t=1}^{k} p_t(T)$

barrier: $\Delta = \min_{t,j} \Delta_t^j$ (the logit gap)

low T: $r(T) \approx m\, e^{-\Delta/T}$ (Arrhenius)

The gaps change from cycle to cycle because the context grows: Δ_c deepens while the model repeats itself (Proposition 2) and in practice saturates (Section 7.3).

Figure 10: A repetition loop as a periodic orbit of clock 3 with noise-driven exits. Along the loop the sampler keeps the greedy token a_t with probability p_t (solid arrows). Every other token j is an exit whose probability is set by its logit gap Δ_t^j to the loop token, exactly as a Boltzmann factor with barrier Δ_t^j and temperature T (dashed arrows). The smallest gap acts as the barrier height in Kramers' escape problem.

grows with the number of times it already appears in the context. Unlikelihood training (Welleck et al., 2019), truncation rules (Hewitt et al., 2022; Meister et al., 2022) and feedback control of perplexity (Basu et al., 2020) are partly attempts to keep the chain out of these attractors; Fu et al. (2020) give a theoretical analysis of why they form. Recent work studies the inside of the loop: how it shows up in residual-stream dynamics before it becomes visible in the output (Zhang et al., 2026b), and the conditions under which a loop "locks" so that escape becomes impossible in practice under a given sampler (Chen & Wang, 2026). Loops also appear at the level of whole texts. Repeated paraphrasing converges to period-two attractor cycles even with sampling noise (Wang et al., 2025). Reasoning models loop too, mostly at low temperature, which Pipis et al. (2025) trace to errors in learning hard steps of a task and to temporally correlated errors.

Escape from a loop has the structure of the noise-driven escape problem of Section 2.2. Suppose the chain has locked into a loop of period k with tokens $a_1, \ldots, a_k$. As long as the sampler keeps choosing the loop token, the context is deterministic, so the logits z_t along the loop are fixed numbers. Define the logit gaps $\Delta_t^j = z_t(a_t) - z_t(j)$ for $j \neq a_t$; all are positive because the loop is the greedy path. The probability of staying in the loop at step t is

$$p_t(T) = \frac{1}{1 + S_t(T)}, \qquad S_t(T) = \sum_{j \neq a_t} e^{-\Delta_t^j/T}, \tag{15}$$

and the probability of leaving during one cycle is $r(T) = 1 - \prod_{t=1}^{k} p_t(T)$ (Figure 10). Chen & Wang (2026) use the same product of per-step continuation probabilities to ask when a sampler locks a loop exactly, with probability one, and show that plain temperature sampling never does. Here a loop locks in a weaker, probabilistic sense: the probability of never escaping is positive (Proposition 2), or escape takes longer than the generation (Section 7.3).

Proposition 1 (Arrhenius law for loop escape)**.** *Let* $\Delta_{\min} = \min_t \min_{j \neq a_t} \Delta_t^j$ *and let* m *be the number of pairs* (t, j) *that attain it. Then* $r(T) \leq \sum_t S_t(T)$ *for all* $T > 0$*, and*

$$r(T) = m\, e^{-\Delta_{\min}/T} \big(1 + o(1)\big) \quad \text{as } T \to 0, \qquad \text{so} \qquad \lim_{T \to 0} T \log r(T) = -\Delta_{\min}. \tag{16}$$

Proof. Since $1 - \prod_t (1 - q_t) \leq \sum_t q_t$ for $q_t \in [0, 1]$, and $1 - p_t = S_t/(1 + S_t) \leq S_t$, the bound follows. As $T \to 0$, each $S_t(T)$ is dominated by its smallest gaps, $S_t(T) = m_t e^{-\delta_t/T}(1 + o(1))$ with $\delta_t = \min_j \Delta_t^j$, and $1 - \prod_t p_t = \sum_t S_t + O(\max_t S_t^2)$. The terms with $\delta_t = \Delta_{\min}$ dominate the sum. □

The logit gap therefore plays the role of the barrier height ΔU in Kramers' formula (Kramers, 1940), and T plays the role of noise intensity. Proposition 1 follows almost directly from the Gibbs form of the softmax. The barrier, however, changes with time. Because loops reinforce themselves (Xu et al., 2022), the gaps grow with each completed cycle, so the well deepens while the chain sits in it. Let Δ_c be the smallest gap during cycle c and $r_c(T)$ the escape probability during that cycle. The probability of never leaving is $\prod_{c\geq 1}(1 - r_c(T))$, which is positive exactly when $\sum_c r_c(T) < \infty$ (given $r_c < 1$).

Proposition 2 (Deepening wells lock)**.** *If $\Delta_c \geq \Delta_1 + b\,(c-1)$ for some $b > 0$, then for every $T > 0$ the probability of never escaping is at least $1 - k(|\mathcal{V}| - 1)\, e^{-\Delta_1/T}/(1 - e^{-b/T})$ whenever this bound is positive, and it is positive for every $T > 0$. If instead the logits along the loop converge from cycle to cycle, so that $\Delta_c \to \Delta_\infty < \infty$, escape eventually happens with probability one, but the expected number of cycles before escape grows like $e^{\Delta_\infty/T}$ as $T \to 0$.*

Proof. By the bound in Proposition 1, $r_c \leq k(|\mathcal{V}| - 1)e^{-\Delta_c/T}$, which is summable under linear growth, and $\prod_c(1 - r_c) \geq 1 - \sum_c r_c$. If the logits converge, then r_c tends to a positive limit and the second statement follows from the first part of Proposition 1. □

Between linear growth and saturation lies a growth law with a sharp threshold in temperature.

Proposition 3 (Locking temperature)**.** *If $\Delta_c = a + \gamma \ln c$ for all $c \geq 1$ with $\gamma > 0$, the probability of never escaping is positive for $T < \gamma$, and escape happens with probability one for $T \geq \gamma$. For $T > \gamma$ the probability of staying in the loop for N cycles is $\exp\big(-\Theta(N^{1-\gamma/T})\big)$.*

Proof. At the step of cycle c that attains Δ_c, $1 - p_t = S_t/(1 + S_t) \geq \frac{1}{2}\min(1, e^{-\Delta_c/T})$, so $r_c \geq \frac{1}{2}\min(1, e^{-\Delta_c/T})$, and Proposition 1 gives $r_c \leq k(|\mathcal{V}|-1)e^{-\Delta_c/T}$. For large c both bounds are constant multiples of $c^{-\gamma/T}$, so $\sum_c r_c$ converges exactly when $\gamma/T > 1$, and $\prod_c(1-r_c) > 0$ exactly when the sum converges. For $T > \gamma$, $r_c \to 0$, so $-\log\prod_{c\leq N}(1 - r_c)$ is within constant factors of $\sum_{c\leq N} c^{-\gamma/T} = \Theta(N^{1-\gamma/T})$. □

Proposition 3 gives an infinite-horizon locking temperature $T_{\text{lock}} = \gamma$, below which survival decays to a positive constant and above which it decays as a stretched exponential. Linear growth locks at every temperature and saturating growth at none, so the three cases of Propositions 2 and 3 cover the possible outcomes for an unbounded generation. A real generation has a finite budget of N cycles. If the barrier has saturated at Δ_∞ and the escape probability per cycle is $m\, e^{-\Delta_\infty/T} \ll 1$, survival over N cycles equals one half at

$$T_{1/2}(N) \approx \frac{\Delta_\infty}{\ln\big(mN/\ln 2\big)}, \tag{17}$$

so the locking temperature observed in a saturating loop falls like $1/\ln N$ with the length of the generation. In practice logits are bounded, so the gaps cannot grow without limit. Experiment 3 (Section 7.3) measures Δ_c along real loops of GPT-2 and Pythia-160M, tests Propositions 1 and 2 against the exact survival probabilities and against Monte Carlo sampling, and asks which growth law the barriers follow.

5.3 Temperature-driven transitions

At the level of statistics over many generations, temperature produces something close to a phase transition. Nakaishi et al. (2024) varied T in GPT-2 and found a low-temperature phase with repetitive structure, a high-temperature phase of incoherent text, and power-law correlations close to those of natural language at the transition point. Seen from clock 3, both phases are failures, and useful text lives in a window between them. The lower edge of the window is the loop escape of Section 5.2. The upper edge, where sampling noise spreads over so much of the vocabulary that the text loses coherence, has no dynamical definition yet, and Experiment 3 locates it only through proxies. Arnold et al. (2024) proposed statistical methods to detect such transitions automatically from output distributions. Jones (2026) found that in the continuous feedback version of generation, temperature and activation steering move the system between periodic orbits and chaos with positive finite-time Lyapunov exponents, with period-doubling scaling and periodic orbits proved by interval arithmetic. In chain-of-thought trajectories, Jaca et al. (2026) report sensitive dependence

on initial conditions together with bounded evolution and fractal structure in hidden-state space. Sorting many generated trajectories into regimes (fixed point, periodic, irregular) without labels is a response-regime identification problem, for which unsupervised data-driven methods exist in mechanics (Farid, 2024).

5.4 Drift over long horizons

Training uses teacher forcing, while generation feeds the model its own outputs. Small errors therefore compound along clock 3, a problem known as exposure bias (Bengio et al., 2015; Wang & Sennrich, 2020). Errors snowball in multi-step reasoning (Dziri et al., 2023) and in hallucinated justifications (Zhang et al., 2023a), and next-token prediction can fail on planning tasks that require looking ahead (Bachmann & Nagarajan, 2024). In dynamical terms these are statements about the growth of perturbations along a trajectory of the closed-loop system, which is what Lyapunov exponents measure.

5.5 Outer loops: when generation feeds training

The slow-fast separation of Section 2.1 breaks when generated text is used for training. Training repeatedly on a model's own outputs makes the tails of the distribution disappear (Shumailov et al., 2023; Alemohammad et al., 2023); whether the process stays near the original model depends on the fraction of real data in each round (Bertrand et al., 2023). Reinforcement learning from human feedback reduces output diversity (Kirk et al., 2023), which can be read as a contraction of the set of trajectories that clock 3 visits. These are dynamical systems over model versions, a fourth and much slower clock.

5.6 Language models as models of dynamical systems

A different line of work asks whether language models can forecast dynamical systems placed in their context. Pretrained models forecast time series zero-shot (Gruver et al., 2023) and extrapolate trajectories of physical systems with accuracy that improves with context length (Liu et al., 2024). Chaotic systems serve as a benchmark for such forecasters (Gilpin, 2021; 2023; Pathak et al., 2018), and training on data from cellular automata at the edge of chaos produces models with better downstream reasoning (Zhang et al., 2024). These results are about the content a model processes, not about the model as a dynamical system, but they share tools with this paper.

6 The Three-Clock Dictionary

Table 2 collects the results of Sections 3, 4 and 5. Each row is a concept from nonlinear dynamics and each column is a clock. A cell names the observed behavior that the concept describes on that clock and marks its evidence level: P when the correspondence is proved for a model of the system, M when it has been measured in trained networks, and C when it is a conjecture. A question mark means that we found no work that tests the concept on that clock.

Reading the table by rows. Fixed points, stability and Lyapunov exponents have been used on all three clocks, although with different meanings: on clock 1 they describe a single finite trajectory, on clock 2 the long-run behavior of an optimizer, and on clock 3 a random process. Phase transitions and escape appear on clocks 2 and 3 but not on clock 1, where the number of steps is fixed and small, so there is no long-time limit in which a transition could be sharp. Even so, the metastability result of Geshkovski et al. (2024) shows that finite-time transients on clock 1 can be analyzed with care.

Reading the table by columns. Clock 2 is the best covered column, because optimization theory has always been a theory of iterated maps. Clock 1 is covered mostly by results at initialization and by models with simplified attention. Clock 3 is the youngest column, and most of its entries date from 2024 or later.

Where the analogies are weak. First, clock 1 runs for a fixed and small number of steps (between 6 and about 100 layers), so asymptotic notions such as attractors and Lyapunov exponents must be replaced by finite-time versions. Second, clock 2 is driven by a data stream whose statistics are not stationary in general,

Concept	Clock 1: layer time ℓ	Clock 2: training time t	Clock 3: generation time n
Fixed point	Tokens collapse to a cluster; rank collapse P (Geshkovski et al., 2023b; Dong et al., 2021). Massive activations nearly input independent M (Sun et al., 2024)	Convergence to a minimum; neural collapse at the end of training M (Papyan et al., 2020)	Period-one loops (one token repeated) as the simplest case of degenerate repetition M (Holtzman et al., 2019)
Linear stability, Jacobian spectrum	Dynamical isometry; layer Jacobians of trained models P/M (Pennington et al., 2017; Fernando & Guitchounts, 2026)	Sharpness vs. $2/\eta$ M (Cohen et al., 2021)	Derivative of the feedback map factorizes through $1/T$ M (Jones, 2026)
Finite-time Lyapunov exponent	Ridges in input space separate classes M (Storm et al., 2023); per-layer profile over training M (Sec. 7.1)	Sensitivity of runs to minibatch noise early in training M (Frankle et al., 2019)	Divergence of nearby generations M (Jaca et al., 2026; Jones, 2026)
Edge of chaos, criticality	Order-chaos transition at initialization sets trainable depth P (Poole et al., 2016; Schoenholz et al., 2016)	Edge of stability M (Cohen et al., 2021)	Critical temperature with power-law text statistics M (Nakaishi et al., 2024)
Limit cycle (periodic orbit)	?	Period-2 orbits of GD P (Chen & Bruna, 2022); SGD converges to cycles P (Chaudhari & Soatto, 2017)	Repetition loops M (Xu et al., 2022); paraphrase 2-cycles M (Wang et al., 2025); loops converge in hidden-state space M (Exp. 3)
Period doubling, route to chaos	?	Larger step sizes give period doubling and chaos in minimal models P (Zhu et al., 2022; Kong & Tao, 2020); period-2 orbit, then irregular oscillation, in a transformer M (Exp. 2)	Feigenbaum scaling in embedding feedback M (Jones, 2026)
Fractal boundary	?	Trainable vs. divergent hyperparameters M (Sohl-Dickstein, 2024); interleaved trainable and divergent step sizes M (Exp. 2); fractal attractors of optimizers M (Tuci et al., 2026)	?
Basin of attraction	Class regions bounded by FTLE ridges M (Storm et al., 2023)	Which minimum is reached depends on step size and batch size M (Jastrzębski et al., 2017)	Prompts that do or do not fall into loops C
Metastability, slow manifold	Multi-cluster states last exponentially long P (Geshkovski et al., 2024)	Plateaus P (Saxe et al., 2013); slow phase of pretraining M (Zhang et al., 2026a; Wen et al., 2024)	Long coherent stretches before drift C
Saddle and ghost	?	Saddles dominate M (Dauphin et al., 2014); abrupt learning from a ghost P (Dinc et al., 2025)	?
Phase transition	?	Grokking P/M (Rubin et al., 2023; Power et al., 2022); induction heads M (Olsson et al., 2022)	Low-T repetitive vs. high-T incoherent phase M (Nakaishi et al., 2024; Arnold et al., 2024); narrow coherent window between them, also in a reasoning model M (Exp. 3)
Noise-driven (Kramers) escape	?	Escape of SGD from minima P (Xie et al., 2020; Mori et al., 2021)	Escape from repetition loops, logit gap as barrier P/M (Prop. 1, Exp. 3); locking temperature P (Prop. 3), horizon-dependent in practice M (Exp. 3)
Synchronization, consensus	Clustering as consensus; Kuramoto form P (Geshkovski et al., 2023b; Li et al., 2026); synchronization by noise P (Agazzi et al., 2026)	?	Collective dynamics of interacting models P (Krishnamurthy et al., 2026)
Koopman, linearization	Local linear description of each layer M (Fernando & Guitchounts, 2026)	Koopman-based training and pruning M (Dogra & Redman, 2020; Redman et al., 2021); lazy regime P (Jacot et al., 2018)	?
Conservation law, symmetry	Gradient-flow structure of attention P (Sander et al., 2021b)	Symmetries give conserved quantities that finite steps break P (Kunin et al., 2020)	?

Table 2: The Three-Clock Dictionary. Each cell gives the behavior that a dynamical-systems concept describes on one clock, with its evidence level (P: proved in a model; M: measured in trained networks; C: conjecture) and representative references. Question marks are cells for which we found no study; they define the open problems of Section 8.

and by learning-rate schedules, which makes it a non-autonomous system. Third, the state of clock 3 is the whole context, so its dimension grows with time and the chain never returns to an earlier state. Statements about loops and attractors on clock 3 are therefore about the projection of the state onto recent tokens. Each of these differences limits which theorems can be imported from the classical theory without change.

7 Three experiments, one per clock

Each experiment below takes one concept from Table 2 and measures it on open models. Every run fits on a two-core CPU; most take under an hour, and the largest models take a few hours. Details are in Appendix A, and the code reproduces every number.

7.1 Experiment 1: the Lyapunov profile of the residual stream over training (clocks 1 and 2)

Question and setup. Finite-time Lyapunov exponents equation 4 describe how a forward pass stretches perturbations, layer by layer. How does this profile change as the model trains? This question couples clock 1 to clock 2 (**OP 1**). We use the public training checkpoints of Pythia (Biderman et al., 2023): eleven checkpoints of Pythia-70M (6 layers), from initialization to step 143,000, and six checkpoints of Pythia-160M (12 layers). Each block is treated as a map F_ℓ on the full residual stream of a 16-token context. For each block we estimate the largest singular value σ_ℓ of its Jacobian by power iteration and report the relative exponent

$$\tilde{\lambda}_\ell = \log \sigma_\ell - \log\left(\|x^{\ell+1}\|/\|x^\ell\|\right), \tag{18}$$

which measures stretching beyond the growth of the residual norm. For the whole stack we report $\Lambda = \frac{1}{L}\log\sigma_{\max}(DF_{0\to L})$, and the ratio $\kappa = \log\sigma_{\max}(DF_{0\to L})/\sum_\ell \log\sigma_\ell$. Since $\sigma_{\max}$ of a product is at most the product of the σ_ℓ, $\kappa \le 1$ whenever $\sum_\ell \log\sigma_\ell > 0$, which holds throughout our measurements, and κ near one means that the most expanded direction of each layer is passed on to the next. Values are means over eight prompts, and κ is the ratio of the two means.

Results. Figure 11 shows three things. First, at initialization both models have the same profile, decreasing with depth ($\tilde{\lambda}_\ell$ from 1.20 to 0.53 in Pythia-70M and from 1.19 to 0.39 in Pythia-160M), which reflects the shared initialization scheme. Second, training makes every layer more expansive. The mean of $\tilde{\lambda}_\ell$ over layers rises from 0.75 to 2.32 in Pythia-70M and from 0.59 to 2.17 in Pythia-160M, and it is still rising at the last checkpoint. The rise is not monotone at the start, since at step 128 the deepest layers of Pythia-70M contract further (layer 6 drops from 0.53 to 0.22) before all layers expand. Third, the whole stack does not follow. In Pythia-70M, Λ goes from 0.87 to about 1.1 and stays between 1.11 and 1.18 from step 4,000 onward, which is under 3% of training. In Pythia-160M it moves from 0.45 to 0.58. As a result the coherence κ falls during training, from 0.67 to 0.36 in Pythia-70M and from 0.52 to 0.22 in Pythia-160M.

Reading. Training produces layers that are individually more sensitive to perturbations, while the expanding directions of consecutive layers become less aligned, so the forward pass as a whole stretches perturbations only moderately. The depth-averaged exponent settles early, while the per-layer exponents keep changing. This is consistent with the observation that the normalized singular value spectra of the weights stabilize early in pretraining (Zhang et al., 2026a), now seen through the Jacobians of the forward map. These are measurements on two small models with short contexts and a small prompt set. Whether the same pattern holds at scale, and whether κ predicts robustness to perturbations or the success of model editing, is part of **OP 1**.

7.2 Experiment 2: a learning-rate bifurcation diagram (clock 2)

Question and setup. How does the long-run behavior of gradient descent on a transformer change with the step size η? We train a one-block transformer (two heads, width 32) with full-batch gradient descent on next-token prediction of sequences from a fixed random Markov chain, for 56 step sizes between 0.02 and 4. Within one seed every step size starts from the same initialization and sees the same data, and we repeat the sweep for three seeds that change both. Full batches remove minibatch noise, so any irregularity comes

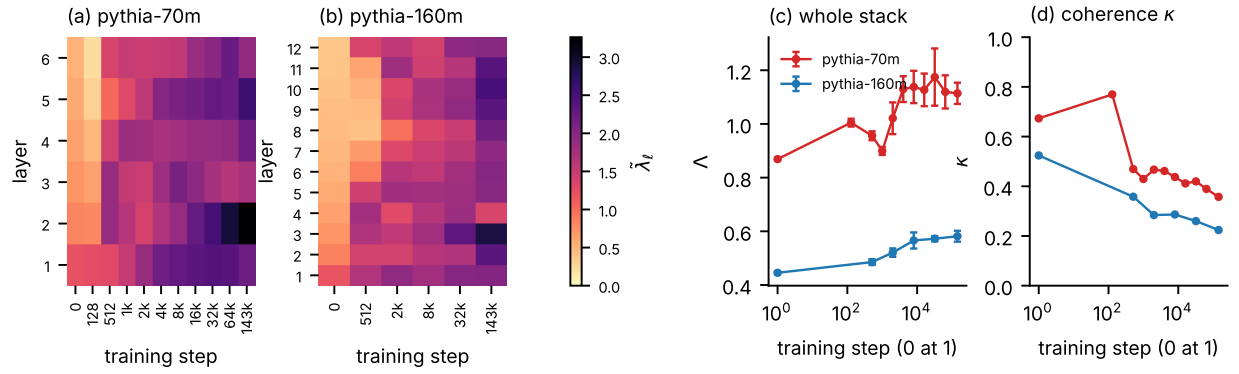


Figure 11: Experiment 1: finite-time Lyapunov exponents of the residual stream across public Pythia checkpoints. (a, b) Relative per-layer exponent $\tilde{\lambda}_\ell$ (stretching of the top singular direction beyond the growth of the residual norm) for each layer and checkpoint. (c) Depth-averaged exponent of the whole stack, Λ; bars: standard deviation over prompts. (d) Coherence κ between per-layer and whole-stack stretching; values below one mean that the most expanded directions of consecutive layers are not aligned.

from the map equation 2 itself. For each run we record the last 400 losses and the sharpness $\lambda_{\max}$ at the end.

Results. Figure 12 shows three regimes. In each seed, 48 of the 56 step sizes train. Across these 144 runs the final sharpness sits just above the stability threshold, with $\eta\lambda_{\max}/2$ having median 1.07 and range $[1.00, 1.21]$ across two decades of step size (panel b). This is the edge-of-stability behavior of Cohen et al. (2021), and in this model it holds over the entire trainable range we tested. None of the runs settles on a fixed point. Removing the slow downward trend of the loss shows what the iterate does instead (panels a and c). For $\eta < 0.05$ the fluctuations alternate in sign at every step, a period-2 orbit riding on the slow descent, and the median lag-1 autocorrelation of the detrended loss over the ten smallest step sizes is -0.99, -0.99 and -0.97 in the three seeds. As η grows the fluctuations become larger and less regular. The median lag-1 autocorrelation rises to between -0.95 and -0.92 for $0.05 \le \eta < 0.3$, between -0.74 and -0.68 for $0.3 \le \eta < 1$, and between -0.66 and -0.32 for $\eta \ge 1$. The edge of trainability depends on the seed. In seed 0 every $\eta \ge 2.04$ diverges, while in seeds 1 and 2 divergent and trainable step sizes interleave between 1.5 and 2.5, and in seed 1 the largest trainable step size (2.47) lies above the smallest divergent one (1.68).

Reading. In dictionary terms, the trainable range of this model is a sequence from a period-2 orbit near the stability boundary, through increasingly irregular oscillation, to divergence. This is the picture that minimal models predict (Chen & Bruna, 2022; Zhu et al., 2022; Kong & Tao, 2020), here measured on a transformer with attention and layer normalization. The interleaving of trainable and divergent step sizes near the edge is consistent with the fractal trainability boundary reported by Sohl-Dickstein (2024), although a grid of 56 points cannot measure a fractal dimension. We do not claim a full period-doubling cascade, since with 400-step tails on top of a slowly drifting loss we cannot resolve periods above two.

Why the sharpness sits above $2/\eta$. In 26 trainable runs (three seeds, eight or nine step sizes each) we continued gradient descent for 200 to 400 steps and computed, at consecutive iterates, the top six Hessian eigenpairs by Lanczos iteration, the curvature along the step, a finite-time Lyapunov spectrum of the gradient-descent map and the leading multipliers of the two-step Jacobian by Arnoldi iteration (Appendix A.2). The sharpness at the iterates sits 5% to 14% above the threshold ($\eta\lambda_{\max}/2$ between 1.05 and 1.14, median 1.11), and two to six eigenvalues exceed $2/\eta$ at every iterate (median four). The curvature of the Hessian averaged over the segment between consecutive iterates, taken along the step, equals $2/\eta$ to within 0.2% in every run, as the telescoping identity of Litman (2026) requires on average. The stiff directions do not stay in place. The top eigenvectors at consecutive iterates are 74 to 88 degrees apart (median 86), so the top of the spectrum is a cluster whose members exchange order at every step, and the step is only

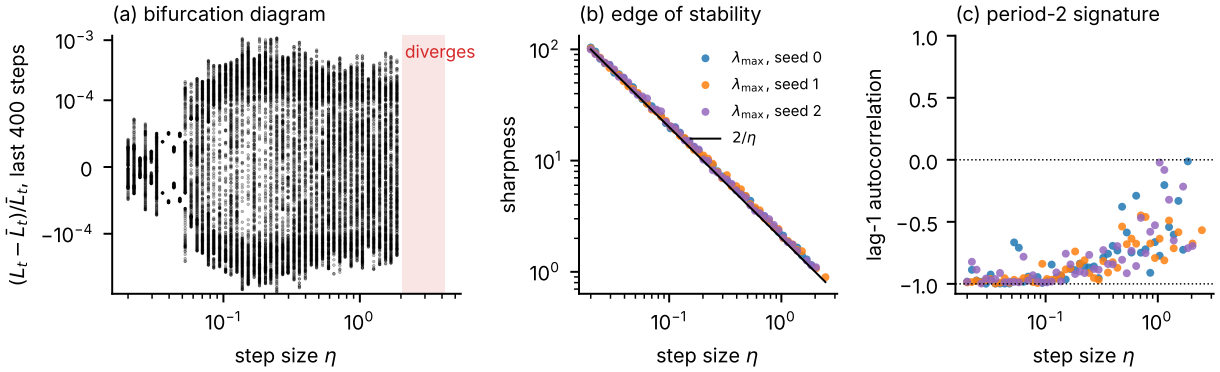


Figure 12: Experiment 2: full-batch gradient descent on a one-block transformer. (a) Bifurcation diagram for seed 0: relative deviation of the last 400 losses from their running mean (9-step window, symmetric-log axis) against the step size. Two branches at small η mark a period-2 orbit; the band at larger η is irregular oscillation; the shaded region diverges. (b) Sharpness at the end of training against $2/\eta$ for three seeds. (c) Lag-1 autocorrelation of the detrended loss for the same runs; -1 is a clean period-2 orbit.

partly aligned with the top eigenvector ($|\cos|$ between 0.08 and 0.42). Locally the two-step map expands, with a largest multiplier between 1.0002 and 1.126 that is often a slow complex pair near $+1$, yet along the trajectory the largest finite-time Lyapunov multiplier per two steps lies between 0.9998 and 1.019 while the loss stays bounded. In this model the edge is therefore a multi-mode regime with neutral or weakly chaotic dynamics, not a single stiff mode on a periodic orbit. A warm-started power iteration, which we used in a first pass, gives ratios of only 1.02 to 1.07, because it averages over the alternating cluster, so reported values of how far the sharpness sits above $2/\eta$ depend on the eigensolver whenever the top of the spectrum is degenerate. Why the oscillation stays bounded with several modes above the threshold is open (**OP 10**).

7.3 Experiment 3: escape from repetition loops (clock 3)

Question and setup. Section 5.2 predicts that escape from a repetition loop follows an Arrhenius law with the logit gap as barrier (Proposition 1), and that loops lock if the barrier grows from cycle to cycle (Proposition 2). We test both on GPT-2 small (Radford et al., 2019) and on the final checkpoint of Pythia-160M (Biderman et al., 2023). From each of 40 prompts we decode greedily for 320 tokens and keep the runs that end in a loop. Because the context along a loop is deterministic, the logits stored during the greedy run give the exact probability of staying in the loop at any temperature, as also used by Chen & Wang (2026), and we check these exact values against Monte Carlo sampling.

Results. Greedy decoding ends in a loop for 37 of the 40 prompts in each model, with periods from 4 to 53 tokens (median 23) in GPT-2 and from 7 to 46 tokens (median 22) in Pythia-160M (Figure 13).

The barrier grows. The median smallest logit gap Δ_c rises from 0.36 in the second cycle of a loop to 2.33 in the sixth and 3.63 in the twentieth in GPT-2, and from 0.47 to 1.83 and then 2.77 by the tenth cycle in Pythia-160M (panel a). The barrier in cycle 6 is larger than in cycle 2 for 36 of 36 GPT-2 loops and 35 of 37 Pythia-160M loops. This is the self-reinforcement reported by Xu et al. (2022), measured here as the depth of a well.

Escape follows the Arrhenius law. For the first cycle after two cycles of burn-in, the escape probability per cycle approaches $e^{-\Delta_{\min}/T}$ at low temperature (panel b). Fitting $\log r$ against $1/T$ recovers the measured barrier with a correlation of 0.997 in both models and a median relative difference of 6.9% (22 GPT-2 loops) and 5.7% (21 Pythia-160M loops). Loops whose escape probability never falls below 10^{-2} on our temperature grid are excluded from the fit (panel c). The exact survival probabilities agree with Monte Carlo sampling. Across 24 comparisons per model (four loops, two temperatures, survival after 1, 2 and 4 cycles, 128 samples

each), the largest absolute difference is 0.062 for GPT-2 and 0.068 for Pythia-160M, and every difference is within two binomial standard errors.

Loops lock below a fairly sharp temperature. The median probability of staying in a loop until the end of the 320-token horizon is 0.89 at $T = 0.31$ in both models, crosses 0.5 at $T \approx 0.53$ (GPT-2) and $T \approx 0.48$ (Pythia-160M), and falls to 0.06 and 0.015 at $T = 0.75$ (panel d). Free sampling gives a consistent picture. With three samples of 200 tokens per prompt and temperature, 68% (GPT-2) and 74% (Pythia-160M) of generations end in a loop at $T = 0.3$, 27% and 48% at $T = 0.5$, at most 6% at $T = 0.7$, and none at $T \geq 0.9$.

The barriers saturate, so locking depends on the horizon. For each loop with at least five cycles after the first, we fit Δ_c for $c \geq 2$ with the logarithmic law of Proposition 3, a linear law and a saturating law $\Delta_c = \Delta_\infty - (\Delta_\infty - a)\, e^{-(c-2)/\tau}$, and compare the fits by the corrected Akaike criterion (Figure 14). The saturating law fits best for 21 of 36 GPT-2 loops and 26 of 37 Pythia-160M loops, the logarithmic law for 8 and 6, and the linear law for 7 and 5. The fitted saturation levels have medians 4.2 and 3.6, reached within a time constant of 3 to 4 cycles. On these models the second case of Proposition 2 applies, and no loop locks in an unbounded generation. The logarithmic law would not explain the measured locking temperatures either. Its rate γ has median 1.48 (GPT-2) and 1.15 (Pythia-160M), more than twice the measured $T_{1/2}$, and exceeds the loop's own $T_{1/2}$ in 35 of 35 and 32 of 35 loops (panel a). The locking temperature of Experiment 3 is therefore a finite-horizon quantity. We recompute it from the exact per-cycle escape probabilities for horizons of 1 to 1024 cycles after burn-in, repeating the last stored cycle beyond the end of the run, which matches the saturation. The median $T_{1/2}$ falls from 0.67 to 0.40 in GPT-2 and from 0.62 to 0.37 in Pythia-160M, and equation 17 fits this decline with a largest deviation of 0.009 and 0.019 (panel c). The fitted constants are effective values (Δ_∞ of 7.0 and 9.0, $\ln m$ of 10.6 and 15.7). They exceed the measured gaps because at $T \approx 0.5$ many competing tokens contribute to escape besides the nearest one, and the single-gap Arrhenius rate with $m = 1$ overestimates $T_{1/2}$ by a median of 37% (GPT-2) and 39% (Pythia-160M), although it ranks the loops correctly (correlation 0.89 and 0.92).

Loops converge onto periodic orbits in hidden-state space. Along each greedy loop we also record the final-layer hidden state h_n of the last token and compute the return distance d_c, the mean of $\|h_n - h_{n-k}\|$ over the k steps of cycle c, divided by the mean norm of the states. If the loop is an attracting periodic orbit of the closed-loop map, $d_c \to 0$. The return distance falls between cycle 2 and cycle 6 in 33 of 36 GPT-2 loops and 35 of 35 Pythia-160M loops. Its median falls from 0.51 in the first cycle to 0.013 in the twelfth in GPT-2, and from 0.060 to 0.008 in Pythia-160M (Figure 18 in Appendix A). It does not reach zero. Over the later cycles it stays near 0.01 in both models, because the context keeps growing, so the closed-loop map is not autonomous and the orbit keeps drifting slowly. Since the logits are a linear function of the final hidden state, the convergence of the state is what makes the barriers saturate.

Coherent text lives in a narrow window between two failures. Raising T ends the loops but eventually produces incoherent text, so we map both failures with the same free generations (Figure 15). A generation counts as a loop by the test above. Otherwise it counts as repetitive if its fraction of repeated 4-grams exceeds the 95th percentile of human continuations of 200 OpenWebText passages (0.091), and as incoherent if its mean negative log-likelihood under a separate reference model (Qwen2.5-0.5B) exceeds the 90th percentile of the human scores (3.49 nats per token, against a human median of 2.92). The remaining generations count as coherent. Exact loops fall below one half at $T \approx 0.43$ (GPT-2) and $T \approx 0.45$ (Pythia-160M), but loops and repetitive text together fall below one half only at $T \approx 0.67$ and $T \approx 0.72$, and incoherent text rises above one half at $T \approx 0.88$ and $T \approx 0.86$. The coherent fraction peaks at $T = 0.8$, at 82% for GPT-2 and 71% for Pythia-160M, and is below 25% at $T = 0.6$ and at $T = 0.9$. Moving the incoherence threshold between the human median and the 95th percentile moves the peak between $T = 0.7$ and $T = 0.8$ and does not widen the window. For each prompt we also take the temperatures at which fewer than half of its samples loop and its median repetition and reference scores are within the human thresholds. This range covers at most four of our twelve temperatures, typically two, lies between 0.6 and 0.9, and is empty for 2 of 40 prompts in GPT-2 and 5 of 40 in Pythia-160M, so for these prompts no single temperature avoids both failures. At the upper edge the entropy of the sampling distribution is 2.3 to 3.1 nats, and at

$T = 2$ it reaches 10.3 nats, 95% of $\log |\mathcal{V}|$, so sampling there is spread over almost the whole vocabulary. These proxies measure surprise and repetition, not meaning, and a reference model of 0.5B parameters is a coarse judge of coherence. Figure 3 shows the three regimes of one prompt in the representations of Section 2.2: the loop is a periodic orbit with sharp spectral lines and long diagonal recurrence lines, and the determinism of the hidden-state trajectory falls from the loop to coherent and then to incoherent text.

Larger models dig deeper wells. We repeated the loop analysis on Pythia-70M, 410M and 1B, which share training data, tokenizer and data order with Pythia-160M (Biderman et al., 2023), so model size is the only variable (Figure 16). Greedy decoding loops for 33 to 37 of the 40 prompts at every size, the barrier grows from cycle 2 to cycle 6 in 34 of 36, 35 of 37, 33 of 33 and 33 of 33 loops from the smallest to the largest model, and the saturating law fits best for 22 to 26 loops per model. The saturated barrier rises with size, with medians 3.0, 3.6, 4.5 and 4.8 from 70M to 1B, and so does the temperature needed to leave a loop. The median $T_{1/2}$ for a horizon of 16 cycles is 0.43, 0.48, 0.59 and 0.64, and for 256 cycles it is 0.36, 0.42, 0.52 and 0.53. Over a 14-fold increase in parameters the locking temperature therefore rises by about half. Free generations of the 410M and 1B models (eight temperatures from 0.3 to 1.2, three samples per prompt) show a wider coherent window than at 160M. The coherent fraction exceeds one half only at $T = 0.8$ for Pythia-160M, and from $T = 0.7$ to $T = 0.9$ for 410M and 1B, with peaks of 81% and 82%. Within this family, larger models produce coherent text over a wider band of temperatures, while the exact loops they do enter are harder to leave.

Reasoning models and the recommended temperature. Vendors of reasoning models prescribe a narrow sampling range. The DeepSeek-R1 model card asks for a temperature between 0.5 and 0.7 "to prevent endless repetitions or incoherent outputs" (DeepSeek-AI, 2025; DeepSeek-AI et al., 2025), and the Qwen3 card recommends $T = 0.6$ with thinking, $T = 0.7$ without, and no greedy decoding (Qwen Team, 2025; Yang et al., 2025). We asked whether these values mark the same window between two failures. Qwen3-0.6B solved the first 18 problems of the GSM8K test set (Cobbe et al., 2021) in thinking mode with plain temperature sampling (no top-k or top-p) and a budget of 1024 tokens, one sample per problem and temperature (Figure 17). We count a problem as reached when the last number of the trace equals the answer, and as solved when the trace also ends inside the budget. The reached fraction is 0.28 at $T = 0.2$, 0.56 at 0.4, 0.61 at 0.6, and 0.22 at both 1.0 and 1.3, and the solved fraction follows the same shape (0.22, 0.28, 0.33, 0.06, 0.11). The best temperature on our grid is therefore the vendor's value, although with 18 problems per temperature the difference between $T = 0.6$ and $T = 0.2$ is at the edge of significance (Fisher exact test, $p = 0.09$; $p = 0.04$ against $T = 1.0$). The two failures are not the ones of Experiment 3. No trace at any temperature ends in an exact loop. At $T = 0.2$ the trace keeps returning to the same step of the problem with small rephrasings ("Alternatively, maybe ...", "Wait, let me check again"), its median fraction of repeated 4-grams is 0.34 against 0.24 at $T = 0.6$, and 13 of 18 traces run out of budget. At $T = 1.3$ the repetition falls to 0.17 while stray tokens from other scripts and broken phrases appear, the incoherent edge of the window. In the language of Section 2.2, the low-temperature failure of this reasoning model is a recurrent orbit, not a periodic one, so the exact escape probabilities used above do not apply and recurrence quantification (Eckmann et al., 1987; Marwan et al., 2007) is the natural tool (**OP 5**). Without thinking, the same model answers the first 20 problems (two samples each, budget 640 tokens) in a median of 250 to 340 tokens, never loops, and solves 0.42 to 0.48 of them at every temperature from 0.2 to 1.0, falling to 0.18 at 1.3, where the text breaks into fragments of code and other scripts. The non-thinking mode thus has the incoherent edge but no repetitive one at this length, and the low-temperature failure appears only in the long thinking traces, consistent with the horizon dependence of the loops above. These runs use a single 0.6B model and a budget far below the tens of thousands of tokens that reasoning models are run with, so they test the shape of the window and cannot confirm the vendors' exact numbers.

Reading. The escape problem on clock 3 has the structure of Kramers' problem, with two differences that matter. The noise acts on a discrete choice through a Gibbs distribution, so the Arrhenius form follows directly from the softmax (Proposition 1) and needs no diffusion approximation. In addition, the barrier is a function of the residence time, so a loop becomes harder to leave the longer the model repeats it. Panel (a) also shows that the deepening is not uniform, and barriers often rise quickly over the first five cycles, pause, and rise again. Escape from a well whose depth grows with the time already spent in it is a non-stationary

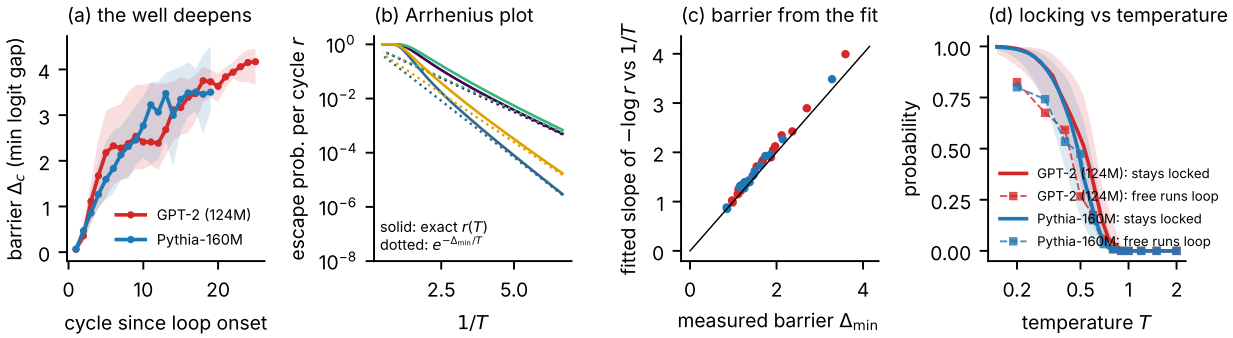


Figure 13: Experiment 3: escape from repetition loops. (a) Barrier Δ_c (smallest logit gap in cycle c) against cycles since loop onset; line: median over loops, band: interquartile range; only cycles reached by at least 10 loops are shown. (b) Exact escape probability per cycle for four GPT-2 loops (solid) and the Arrhenius term $e^{-\Delta_{\min}/T}$ (dotted). (c) Barrier recovered from the slope of $\log r$ against $1/T$ at low temperature, against the measured $\Delta_{\min}$; line: identity. (d) Solid: median probability of staying in the loop until the end of the 320-token horizon, after two cycles of burn-in (band: interquartile range); the number of remaining cycles differs between loops because their onsets differ. Dashed: fraction of free generations of 200 tokens that end in a loop (120 per temperature).

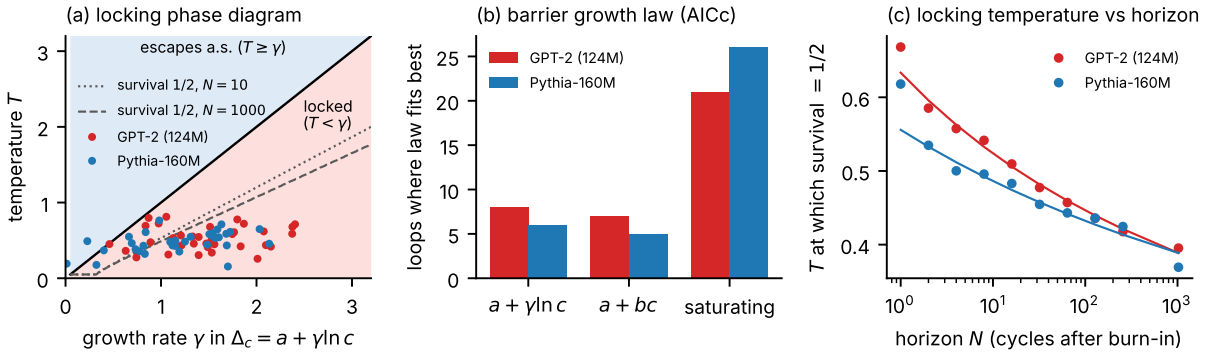


Figure 14: Experiment 3, locking. (a) Phase diagram for the logarithmic barrier $\Delta_c = a + \gamma \ln c$ (Proposition 3): loops lock with positive probability below $T = \gamma$ and escape almost surely above it. Dotted and dashed lines: temperature at which survival over $N = 10$ and $N = 1000$ cycles equals one half, for the single-gap rate with $m = 1$ and the median fitted a. Points: fitted γ and exact finite-horizon $T_{1/2}$ of each loop. (b) Barrier growth law preferred by the corrected Akaike criterion. (c) Median exact $T_{1/2}$ against the horizon N (points) and the fit of equation 17 (lines).

escape problem. Its mechanical analogue is a particle in a well that deepens as the particle settles, and how it scales beyond 1B parameters is open (**OP 5**).

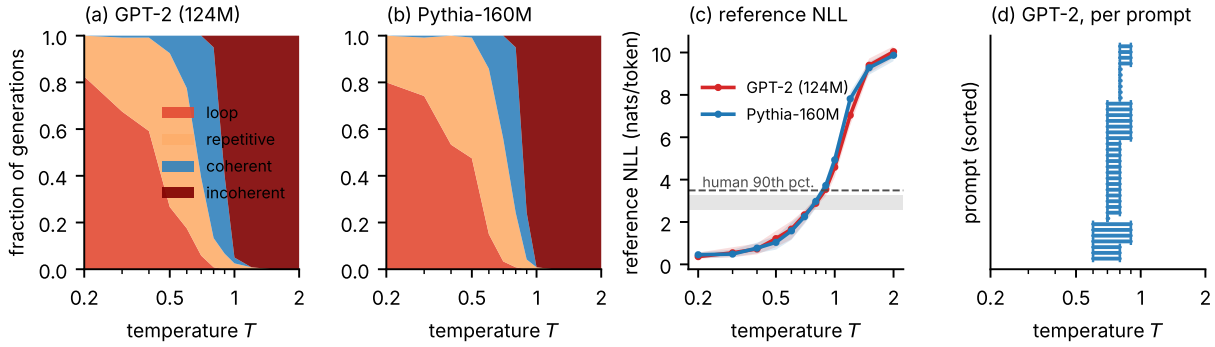


Figure 15: Experiment 3, the coherent window. (a, b) Fraction of free generations (three samples of 200 tokens for each of 40 prompts) that end in a loop, are repetitive (repeated 4-grams above the 95th percentile of human text), are incoherent (reference score above the 90th percentile of human text) or are coherent, against temperature. (c) Median reference score in nats per token (band: interquartile range); gray band: interquartile range of human text; dashed: the incoherence threshold. (d) Coherent temperature range of each GPT-2 prompt, sorted; two prompts with an empty range are not shown.

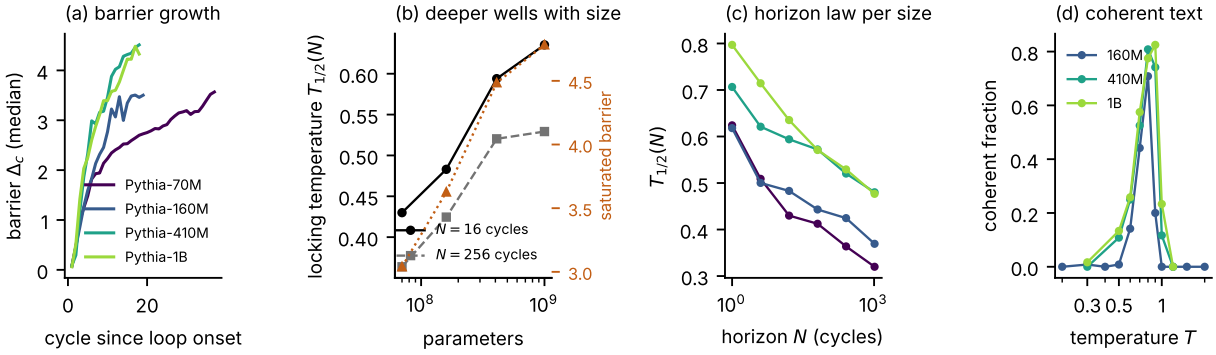


Figure 16: Experiment 3 across model size, Pythia-70M to Pythia-1B (same data and training order). (a) Median barrier Δ_c against the cycle since loop onset (cycles reached by at least 10 loops). (b) Median locking temperature $T_{1/2}(N)$ for horizons of 16 and 256 cycles (left axis) and median saturated barrier Δ_∞ from the saturating fits (right axis) against the number of parameters. (c) $T_{1/2}(N)$ against the horizon for each model. (d) Fraction of coherent free generations against temperature for the three larger models.

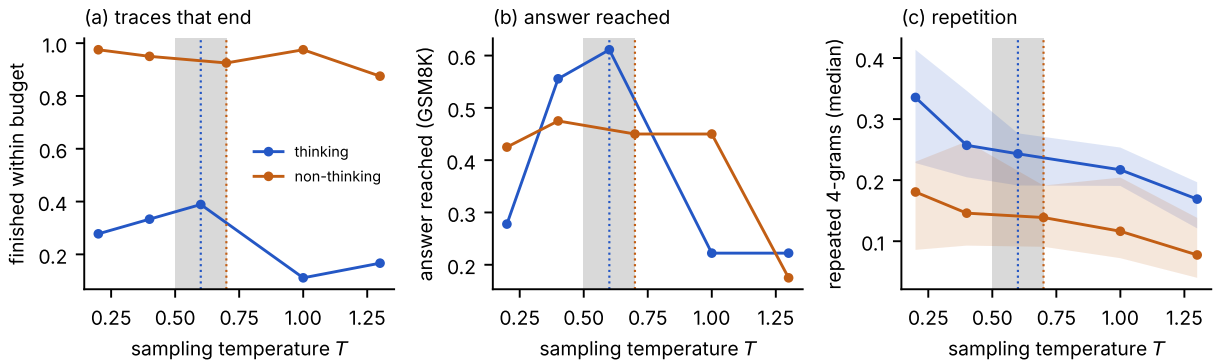


Figure 17: Experiment 3, reasoning model. Qwen3-0.6B on GSM8K test problems with plain temperature sampling, with thinking (18 problems, 1024-token budget) and without (20 problems, two samples each, 640 tokens). (a) Fraction of traces that end inside the budget. (b) Fraction whose last number equals the answer. (c) Median fraction of repeated 4-grams (band: interquartile range). Gray band: the range recommended for DeepSeek-R1; dotted lines: the Qwen3 recommendations for thinking (0.6) and non-thinking (0.7) mode. No trace ends in an exact loop.

8 Open problems

Each problem below comes from an empty or weak cell of Table 2, or from a place where two clocks meet, and each is stated with a first test. Problems **OP 9** and **OP 10** are conjectures that come from the mechanics of nonlinear oscillators. We include them because they make predictions that can be checked, and we do not claim evidence for them yet.

OP 1. Coupling of clocks 1 and 2. How does training reshape the depth dynamics, and which features of the Lyapunov profile settle before the loss does? Experiment 1 gives a first answer for two small models, in which the whole-stack exponent settles within 3% of training while the per-layer exponents keep growing. The natural next test is the full Jacobian spectrum of every layer across the public checkpoints of a model family with more than a billion parameters.

OP 2. Periodic orbits in depth. Do models that reuse a block many times, such as looped and recurrent-depth models (Prairie et al., 2026), have periodic or quasi-periodic orbits in the residual stream, and do these orbits carry computation? Return maps of hidden states over many loop iterations would show such orbits directly.

OP 3. The full Lyapunov spectrum of a language model. Beyond the largest exponent, how many directions expand along a forward pass and along a generation, and what is the resulting attractor dimension? QR-based algorithms (Engelken et al., 2020; Vogt et al., 2020) make this computation feasible for models of GPT-2 size.

OP 4. The type of a loss spike. Are loss spikes in pretraining crossings of the stability boundary, period-doubling cascades, catapults (Lewkowycz et al., 2020), or escapes from a basin? Each type leaves a different signature in the curvature and in the update direction just before the spike, so spikes in open training logs and checkpoints can be classified by these signatures.

OP 5. Escape laws across samplers and scales. Proposition 1 fixes the low-temperature law for plain temperature sampling. How do nucleus sampling and repetition penalties change the barrier, and how does the growth of the barrier from cycle to cycle scale with model size? Within Pythia, from 70M to 1B parameters, the saturated barrier and the locking temperature grow with size (Experiment 3), and whether they keep growing at larger scale is open. Reasoning models add a third question. At low temperature Qwen3-0.6B does not loop but keeps revisiting the same step with small variations, a recurrent orbit without a period, and it is open whether such orbits have an escape law of their own and whether recurrence plots of the trace predict when a reasoning model will run out of budget. A harder version asks for prediction: can the onset of a loop, its growth law and the coherent temperature window of a prompt be read from the prompt and the weights, before any text is generated?

OP 6. Fractal trainability of transformers. Does the fractal boundary between convergent and divergent hyperparameters (Sohl-Dickstein, 2024) persist for transformers trained with Adam, and how does its dimension depend on depth? Fine grids over learning rate and warmup length for small transformers are enough for a first estimate.

OP 7. Metastability in generation. Is the length of a coherent stretch of generated text before drift a metastable residence time, exponentially long in some barrier, like the cluster states in depth (Geshkovski et al., 2024)? Survival curves of coherence, judged by an external model, as a function of temperature would test this.

OP 8. Koopman modes of a forward pass. Can a finite-dimensional linear operator fitted to residual-stream trajectories predict the effect of an intervention several layers ahead, and do its eigenfunctions align with known features? Dynamic mode decomposition on residual streams, compared with the tuned lens (Belrose et al., 2023), is a direct test.

OP 9. Targeted energy transfer (conjecture). In coupled mechanical oscillators, a nonlinear energy sink absorbs vibration energy from a primary system in one direction and irreversibly (Vakakis et al.,

2009; Farid & Gendelman, 2016). We conjecture that a similar one-way transfer of signal energy exists between spectral modes of the residual stream, with massive activations and attention sinks (Sun et al., 2024; Xiao et al., 2023) in the role of the sink. Tracking the energy carried by each singular mode of the layer Jacobians across depth and training, and testing whether transfer into the sink directions is reversible, would confirm or refute this.

OP 10. Escape under internal forcing (conjecture). At the edge of stability the iterate oscillates along stiff directions near the top of the Hessian spectrum, and the other directions see this oscillation as periodic forcing. In mechanics, a periodically forced particle escapes from a potential well when the forcing amplitude crosses a threshold that depends on the forcing frequency (Farid & Gendelman, 2019; Farid, 2022). We conjecture that some loss spikes are escapes of this kind, so that their onset can be predicted from the oscillation amplitude and the local shape of the basin. Gradient descent on a quartic well coupled to an oscillating direction is the simplest test, followed by the same diagnostic on small transformers. The measurements in Section 7.2 add a related question. At the edge several Hessian eigenvalues exceed $2/\eta$, their eigenvectors exchange order at every step, and the largest Lyapunov multiplier of the trajectory stays near one. Self-stabilization (Damian et al., 2022) explains a single mode at the edge; the averaged dynamics of several interacting edge modes, and the exchange of energy between them, is the natural model for this regime.

OP 11. Early warning signals. Near a bifurcation, recovery from perturbations slows down and fluctuations grow. Do grokking, induction-head formation and loss spikes show rising autocorrelation and variance of the loss or of the gradient norm before they happen? Training runs in which the transition step is known, such as those of Power et al. (2022) and Olsson et al. (2022), allow a direct check.

OP 12. Control of clock 3. Can a controller built from the escape analysis keep generation coherent at a lower cost than repetition penalties? Mirostat (Basu et al., 2020) and truncation sampling (Hewitt et al., 2022) at matched quality are the natural baselines. Three first tests on GPT-2 (Appendix A.3) fail in an instructive way. Raising the temperature for one cycle whenever a loop is detected, to the value at which the stay probabilities give a 90% chance of leaving it, cuts the looping generations at $T = 0.3$ from 68% to 6%, but 94% of the outputs remain repetitive. Acting where the barrier is lowest does not help either. Rolling the text back to the first token of a loop, forbidding that token and resampling at $T = 0.5$ (2.2 rollbacks per text on average) removes all exact loops (27% at fixed $T = 0.5$) and lowers the median fraction of repeated 4-grams from 0.43 to 0.31, but 91% of the outputs stay above the human repetition threshold. A feedback controller that raises the temperature when the recent text recurs and lowers it when its surprisal exceeds a target settles at a mean temperature of 0.74 to 0.78 from starting points 0.4, 0.6 and 0.8, close to the center of the window in Figure 15, but its share of coherent texts (21%, 63% and 83%) is no better than the 82% of the best fixed temperature, because the repetitive text produced before the controller reacts remains part of the output and of the context. All three controllers act on the noise, while the trap is stored in the state. Controllers that act on the context or on the hidden state, for example by editing the cache or by adding a steering vector to the residual stream as in activation engineering (Turner et al., 2023; Zou et al., 2023), are the natural next step. In the language of Section 2.2 this moves from changing the noise intensity to applying a control force on the state.

9 Conclusion

A transformer language model is iterated in three ways: over layers, over optimizer steps and over generated tokens. Each iteration has been studied with tools from dynamical systems, mostly by different communities and under different names. We gave the three iterations one formal frame, reviewed the results on each, and summarized them in a dictionary that records which concepts have been proved, measured or only conjectured on which clock. In experiments on open models we found that training makes each layer of a Pythia model more expansive while the coherence of the whole forward pass falls, that gradient descent on a small transformer stays at a multi-mode edge of stability across two decades of step size, and that repetition loops in GPT-2 and Pythia behave as wells whose depth grows while the model sits in them and then saturates, so that whether a loop locks depends on the length of the generation and on the size of the

model, and coherent text lies in a narrow temperature window between repetition and incoherence. A small reasoning model has the same window, centered on its recommended temperature, and its low-temperature failure is recurrent rethinking, with no periodic loop.

A bridge between two fields can describe, explain and solve. This paper describes the three clocks in one vocabulary, shows the correspondences side by side, derives the reduced-order models behind them, and explains several behaviors that the machine learning literature had measured but not accounted for, from the Arrhenius escape from loops to the narrow window of coherent text. It does not yet solve a problem of language models that was unsolved before: our controllers for repetition find the right temperature but do not beat it. We think the third level is within reach, because many problems of language models have counterparts that dynamics has already solved, and the open problems of Section 8 point to where.

Many cells of the dictionary are empty, and several of the open problems sit where two clocks meet, such as the effect of training on the depth dynamics, the feedback of generated text into training, and the prediction of training instabilities with the tools used for escape problems in mechanics. Each of these questions has a counterpart that nonlinear dynamics has studied for decades on pendulums, ships and oscillator networks, and each can be tested with the weights and outputs of open models on a laptop. We hope that the shared vocabulary of this paper helps researchers from both communities recognize the same phenomenon when they meet it, and solve it together.

Code and data

Code to reproduce every figure and number, the raw results, and a maintained list of the papers in this review are available at `https://github.com/maorfarid1/three-clocks`. All experiments run on a CPU.

Broader impact statement

This is a review with small-scale experiments on public models, and we do not foresee direct negative consequences. A better account of repetition loops and of training instabilities could reduce wasted compute in pretraining and make generation more reliable.

Use of AI tools

An AI assistant (Claude, Anthropic) was used to search and verify the literature, draft and edit text, and write and run experiment code under the author's direction. All references were checked against arXiv or Crossref records, all numbers come from the released code, and the author is responsible for every claim in the paper.

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A Experimental details

All experiments run on a CPU with two cores and 7 GB of memory, using PyTorch and Hugging Face Transformers with the public checkpoints of GPT-2 small (Radford et al., 2019) and Pythia (Biderman et al., 2023). The repository contains one script per experiment, the exact command lines, the raw JSON outputs and the plotting scripts. The 40 prompts used in Experiments 1 and 3 are short neutral sentence openings written for this study (for example, "The weather today is cold and cloudy, with a chance of"), and the full list is in the repository.

A.1 Experiment 1: finite-time Lyapunov exponents

For each prompt we take the first T tokens (prompts shorter than T are repeated) and run the model once to record the residual stream $x^0, \dots, x^L$ before the final layer normalization. We then call each block of the Hugging Face implementation directly as a function $F_\ell : \mathbb{R}^{T\times d} \to \mathbb{R}^{T\times d}$, with rotary embeddings and an explicit causal mask, and check that chaining these calls reproduces the model's hidden states (the maximum relative deviation was zero in float32 for every checkpoint). The largest singular value of the Jacobian $DF_\ell(x^\ell)$ is estimated by power iteration on $DF_\ell^\top DF_\ell$, using forward-mode (JVP) and reverse-mode (VJP) products from `torch.func`. The same procedure applied to the composition $F_{L-1} \circ \cdots \circ F_0$ gives the depth-averaged exponent $\frac{1}{L}\log \sigma_{\max}(DF_{0\to L})$. We use eight prompts, contexts of 16 tokens and 10 power iterations per estimate, for eleven Pythia-70M checkpoints (steps 0, 128, 512, 1k, 2k, 4k, 8k, 16k, 32k, 64k and 143k) and six Pythia-160M checkpoints (steps 0, 512, 2k, 8k, 32k and 143k).

A.2 Experiment 2: bifurcation diagram

Data. A first-order Markov chain over $V = 12$ symbols, with transition rows drawn from a Dirichlet distribution with concentration 0.3 (seed 0), generates $N = 64$ sequences of length 13, and the model predicts the next symbol at each of the 12 positions. *Model.* One pre-LN transformer block with causal

attention (two heads, width 32, MLP width 64), learned positional embeddings and a linear readout, in float64. Attention is written out explicitly so that Hessian-vector products work on a CPU. *Training.* Full-batch gradient descent on the mean cross-entropy, from the same initialization for every step size within a seed. Seeds 0, 1 and 2 change both the Markov chain and the initialization. Each run lasts $\max(3000, 600/\eta)$ steps, capped at 30,000, so that all runs cover a comparable amount of gradient-flow time. A run is marked as diverged if the loss exceeds 50 or becomes non-finite. *Measurements.* The last 400 losses of each run, and the top Hessian eigenvalue at the final iterate from 40 steps of power iteration on Hessian-vector products. The step sizes are 56 values spaced geometrically between 0.02 and 4.

Edge-of-stability geometry. For each seed and for nine step sizes spaced geometrically between 0.05 and 1.6, we train as above and continue gradient descent. The curvature along the step is measured over 200 further steps as $\langle g_t - g_{t+1}, g_t\rangle/(2\|g_t\|^2)$, which equals $\eta/2$ times the curvature of the segment-averaged Hessian along the step. Over a separate window of 400 steps we compute, every 50 steps at a pair of consecutive iterates, the top six Hessian eigenpairs by Lanczos iteration (`scipy eigsh` on Hessian-vector products, residuals near 10^{-13}), their mutual angles and the alignment of the step with the top eigenvector; a finite-time Lyapunov spectrum of six vectors with QR reorthogonalization at every step; and, at step 200, the eight largest multipliers of $(I - \eta H_{t+1})(I - \eta H_t)$ by Arnoldi iteration. Power iteration is not suitable for this two-step map, since thousands of flat directions have multipliers near one. The largest step size (1.6) diverged in seed 0, leaving 26 runs. Per-run values are in `results/eos_rotation/`.

A.3 Experiment 3: escape from repetition loops

Loop detection. From each prompt we decode greedily for 320 tokens and store the full logit vector at each step. A loop of period $k \le 64$ is detected when the last $3k$ tokens are k-periodic, and its onset is the earliest index from which the sequence stays k-periodic. *Stay probabilities.* Along the loop the context is deterministic, so the probability equation 15 of producing the loop token at temperature T follows from the stored logits, for 30 temperatures spaced geometrically between 0.15 and 2. From these we compute, for each cycle c, the barrier Δ_c (smallest gap between the loop token's logit and any other logit during the cycle) and the escape probability $r_c(T) = 1 - \prod_{t\in c} p_t(T)$. *Arrhenius fit.* For the first cycle after two completed cycles of burn-in, we fit $\log r$ against $1/T$ by least squares over the temperatures where $10^{-9} < r < 10^{-2}$, and compare the negative slope with $\Delta_{\min}$ of that cycle. *Monte Carlo check.* For the first four loops we sample 128 continuations at $T \in \{0.6, 1.0\}$ (nearest grid temperature) from the context after burn-in, record the first step whose token differs from the loop, and compare the fraction still in the loop after 1, 2 and 4 cycles with the exact survival probability. *Free sampling and coherence.* For each of 12 temperatures between 0.2 and 2 we sample three continuations of 200 tokens from every prompt with plain temperature sampling (no top-k or top-p), record whether each ends in a loop with at least three repetitions, the fraction of repeated 4-grams, and the mean entropy of the sampling distribution along the path. Each continuation is then scored by Qwen2.5-0.5B (Qwen Team, 2024) conditioned on its prompt, as the mean negative log-likelihood per reference token. The human baseline applies the same score to 200 passages of OpenWebText (the `stas/openwebtext-10k` sample), each split into its first 16 GPT-2 tokens as prompt and the next 200 as continuation. *Growth laws.* For each loop with at least five cycles after the first, we fit the barriers Δ_c, $c \ge 2$, with $a + \gamma \ln c$ and $a + bc$ by least squares and with $\Delta_\infty - (\Delta_\infty - a)e^{-(c-2)/\tau}$ by nonlinear least squares, and pick the law with the smallest corrected Akaike criterion. The finite-horizon locking temperature $T_{1/2}(N)$ of a loop is the temperature, interpolated in $\log T$ on the 30-point grid, at which the exact probability of surviving N cycles after burn-in equals one half; beyond the stored cycles the escape probability of the last stored cycle is repeated. We fit equation 17 to the medians for $N \ge 4$. *Escape control.* The controller of **OP 12** samples at a base temperature T_0. When the generated tokens end in at least $\max(2, \lceil 8/k\rceil)$ repetitions of a block of $k \le 64$ tokens, it computes the escape probability of the last cycle on a grid of temperatures from the 64 largest logits of each step, raises the temperature for the next k steps to the smallest value with escape probability q (capped at 1.5), and then returns to T_0. On the 40 prompts with three samples each, $T_0 = 0.3$ and $q = 0.9$ give 6% loops and 94% repetitive outputs (repeated 4-grams above the human 95th percentile), against 68% and 32% at constant $T = 0.3$. A repetition penalty of 1.2 (Keskar et al., 2019) removes loops and repetition but makes 73% of the outputs incoherent by our threshold. *Model size.* For Pythia-70M, 410M and 1B we run the greedy loop analysis without the Monte Carlo check, Pythia-1B in two halves of 20 prompts to fit in memory, and the free generations of 410M and 1B at eight

temperatures in batches of 10 prompts, scoring them with the reference model in a separate pass. *Return distance.* We repeat the greedy runs while storing the final-layer hidden state (after the last layer norm) at each step. Figure 18 shows the median return distance and a projection of one GPT-2 loop on its first two principal components.

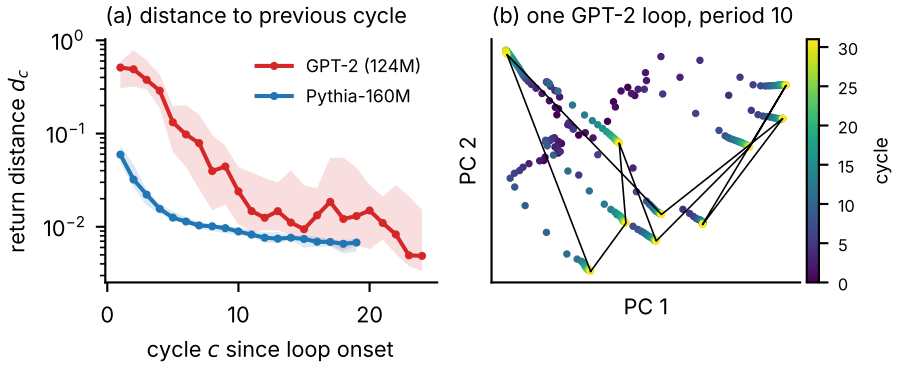


Figure 18: Experiment 3, loops as orbits. (a) Return distance d_c (mean distance between the final hidden state and its value one period earlier, relative to the mean state norm) against the cycle; line: median over loops, band: interquartile range. (b) First two principal components of the final hidden states (each dimension standardized) along one GPT-2 loop of period 10 ("He was a man of great wealth and power."), colored by cycle. Each of the ten states of the cycle converges along its own track; black: the last cycle.

Reasoning model. We use Qwen3-0.6B in float32 with its own chat template, switching thinking on or off through the template flag, and append to each GSM8K question the instruction to reason step by step and put the final answer in `\boxed{}`. Sampling is plain temperature sampling with top-k and top-p disabled, in batches of 6 (thinking) or 10 (non-thinking) left-padded prompts, with a fixed seed per temperature, sample and batch. The answer is the content of the last `\boxed{}` if present and otherwise the last number in the trace, compared numerically with the reference answer. A trace counts as finished when it emits the end-of-turn token inside the budget. Loops are detected as in Experiment 3 with periods up to 256 tokens, and a loop must repeat over at least 30 tokens, which rules out runs such as the zeros of a number cut by the budget. The thinking runs take about 28 minutes per temperature on two CPU cores.

Paired figures and regime atlas. Figures 2, 4, 5 and 9 are produced by `paper/fig_pairs.py`, and Figure 3 by `exp3_escape/atlas.py`. The Duffing oscillator is integrated with the Euler-Maruyama scheme (step 0.025) after a transient of 100 time units and sampled once per time unit. For the recurrence plots the state is standardized and ε is chosen so that 5% of all pairs recur; DET counts diagonal lines of length at least 2 and excludes the main diagonal. The spectral entropy is the Shannon entropy of the normalized Welch spectrum (segments of 256 samples, zero frequency excluded) divided by its maximum. The statistics in Section 2.2 (`exp3_escape/atlas_stats.py`) repeat these measurements for noise seeds 0 to 9 and for the first 10 prompts of Experiment 3; at $T = 0.3$, 9 of the 10 GPT-2 runs end in an exact loop.

Controllers for clock 3. Rollback and kick (`exp3_escape/rollback.py`) samples at a base temperature T_0; when the generated tokens end in a loop it deletes the periodic tail back to its first token, forbids that token at that position and resamples there at T_0. The feedback controller (`exp3_escape/regime_control.py`) updates the temperature after every token from the last $W = 32$ tokens, $T \leftarrow \mathrm{clip}\big(T + 0.05(\rho - 0.02) - 0.01\max(0, s - 3),\ 0.4,\ 1.1\big)$, where ρ is the fraction of 4-grams in the window that already occurred earlier in the generation and s is their mean surprisal at $T = 1$ in nats. The gains were set by hand on three of the 40 prompts; without these three prompts the coherent fractions are 21%, 64% and 82%. Both use the 40 prompts, three samples and 200 tokens of Experiment 3b, and are scored with the same reference model and thresholds, so the constant-temperature rows of Experiment 3b are the baseline.